

— SPM 381 — CONSUMER BEHAVIOR IN SPORT

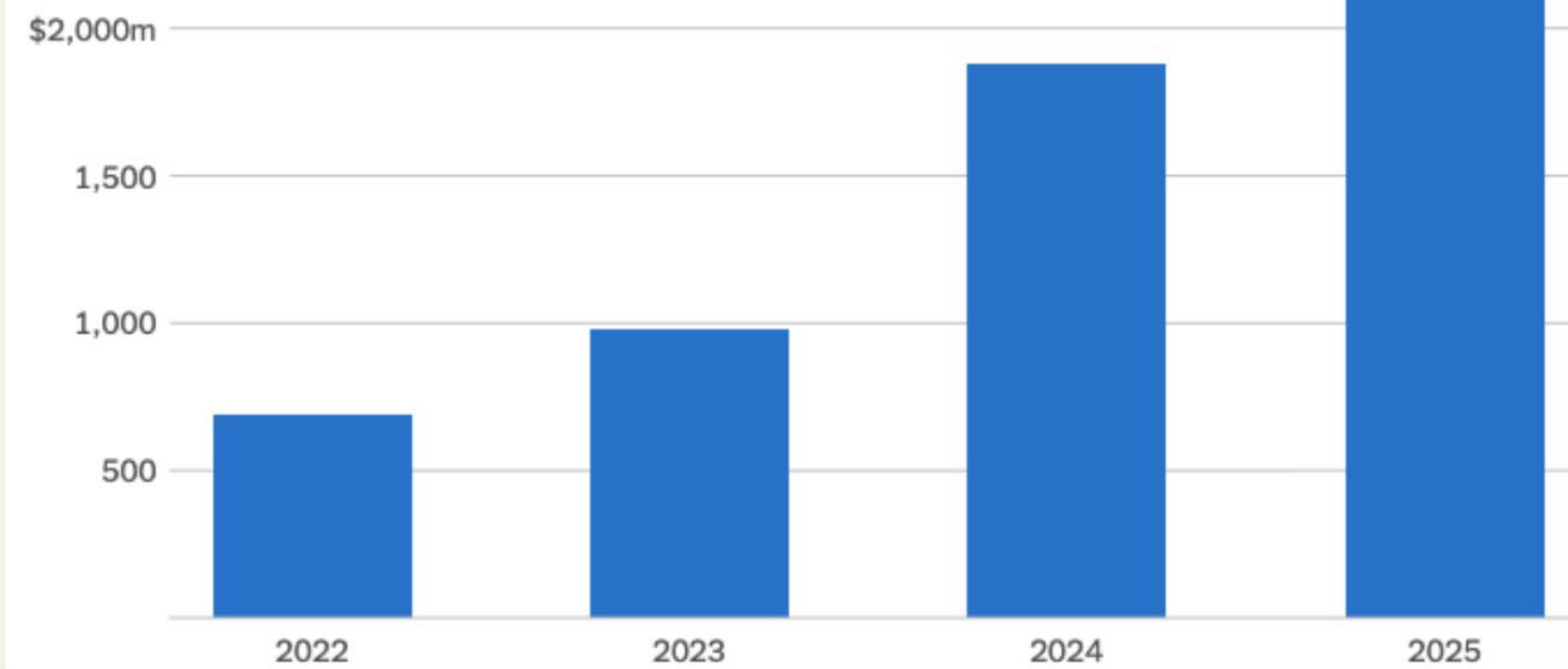
Introduction to Sport Consumer Behavior

Chapter 1

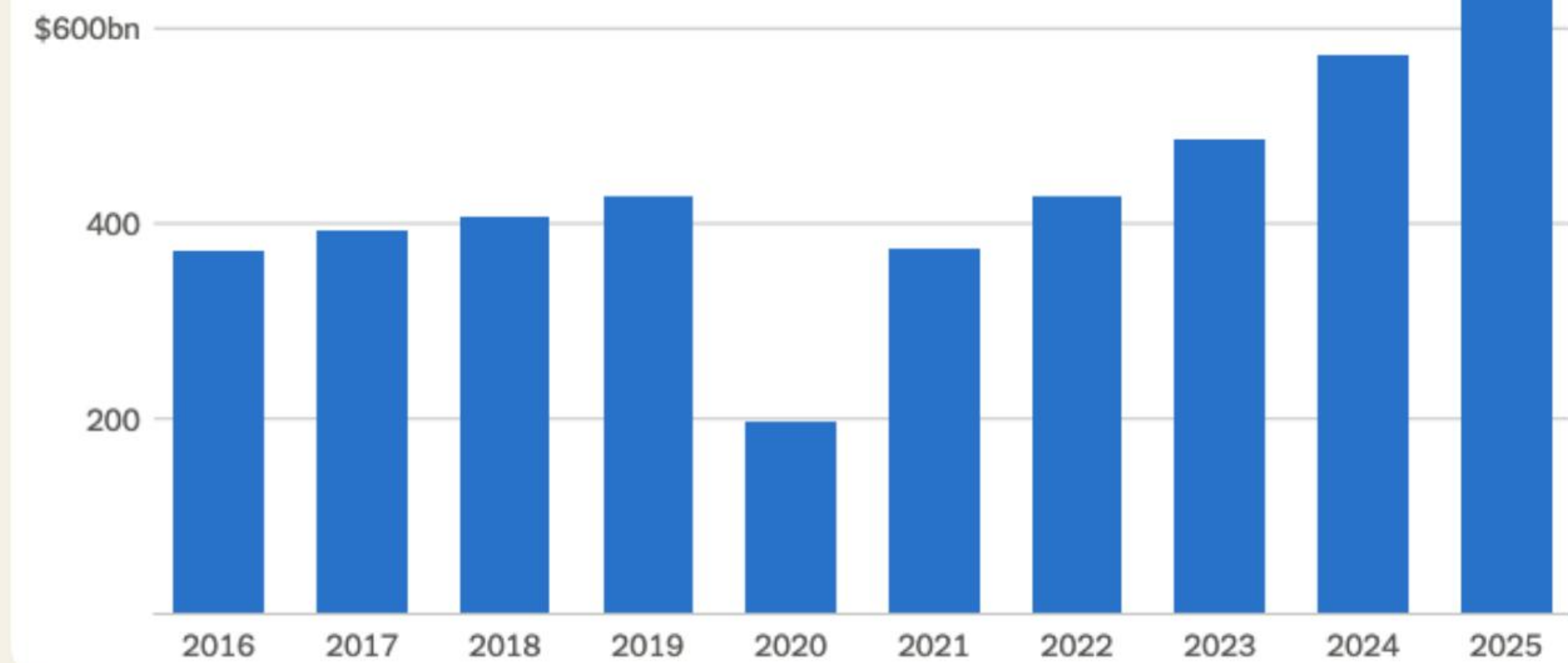
Arcadia University Sport Management · Week 1

Global Sports Economy

Women's sport revenue growth



Sports tourism market size



Global Sports Economy

Sports economy global revenue pools

For 2025



Strategic Questions

How can sports organizations balance the expectations for revenue-generation and commercial growth with team performance and fan trust?

How can data and AI be used to personalize fan experiences, understand community needs, and inform better stadium and district design?

Pervasiveness and Significance of Sport Spectatorship

60%

of the world's population is
interested in sport

88%

of Americans are sport-interested

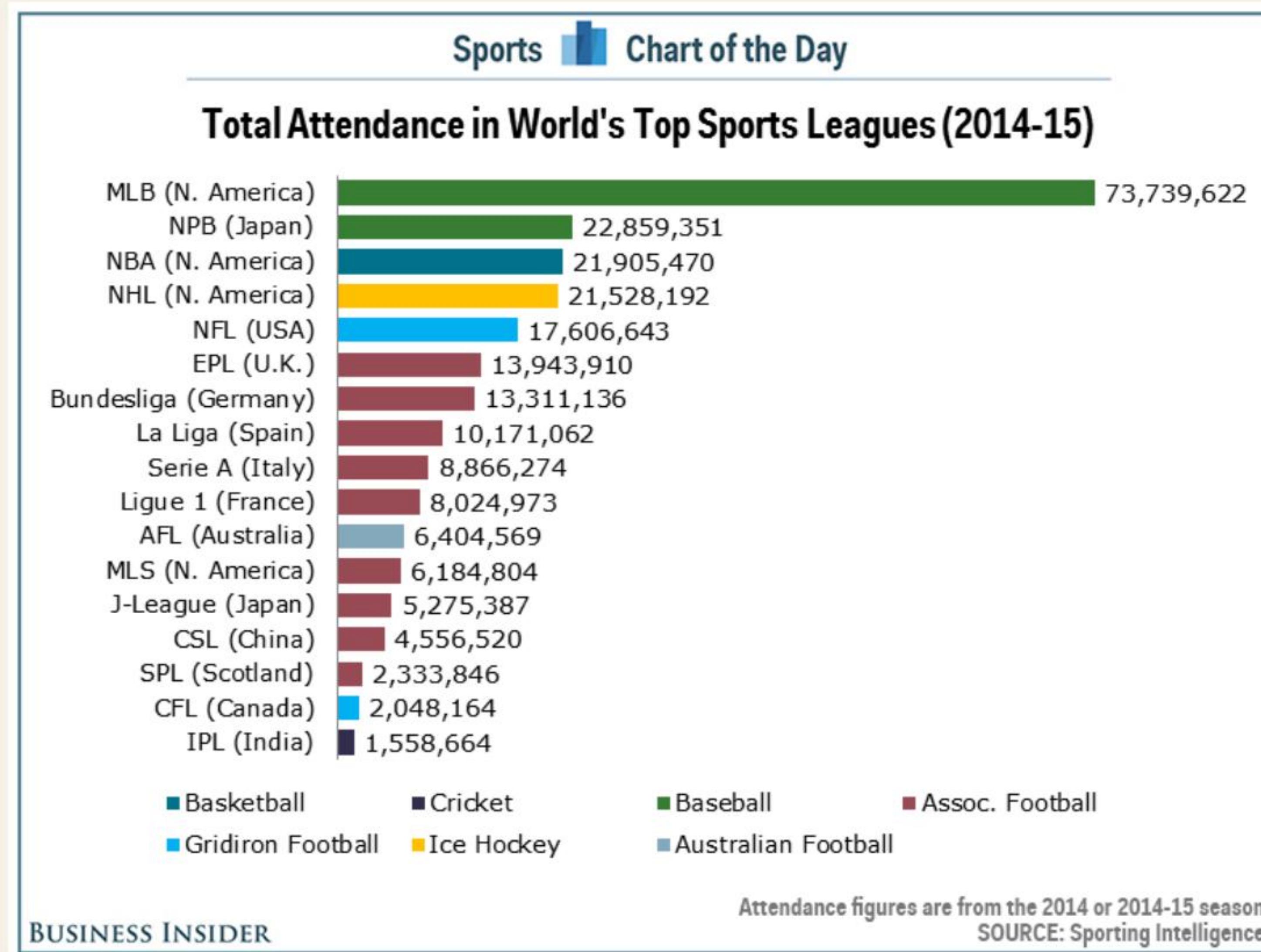
US\$91B

garnered in sport revenue, 2017

- Approximately 60% of the world's population is interested in sport and about 88% of Americans are.
- About US\$91 billion was garnered in sport's revenue in 2017, but the growth is slowing.
- U.S. economy strengthens but fan support softens.
- *Why is this information important to sport marketers and managers?*

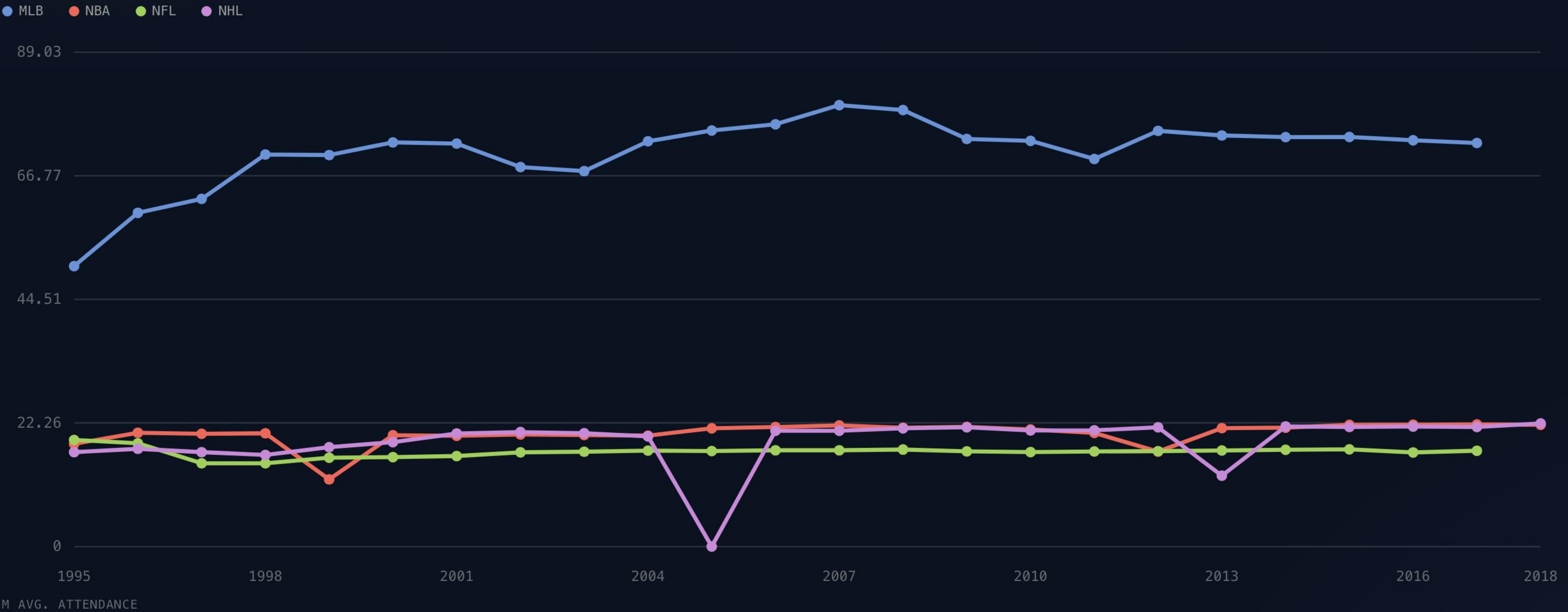
Attendance in World's Top Sports Leagues

- Which graph is a better representation of popularity of the league? Why?
- Any of these numbers or rankings surprise you at all?



Attendance

• *Think about what this graph indicates, based on the trends. Predict where attendance will go from here. Are there any concerns?*



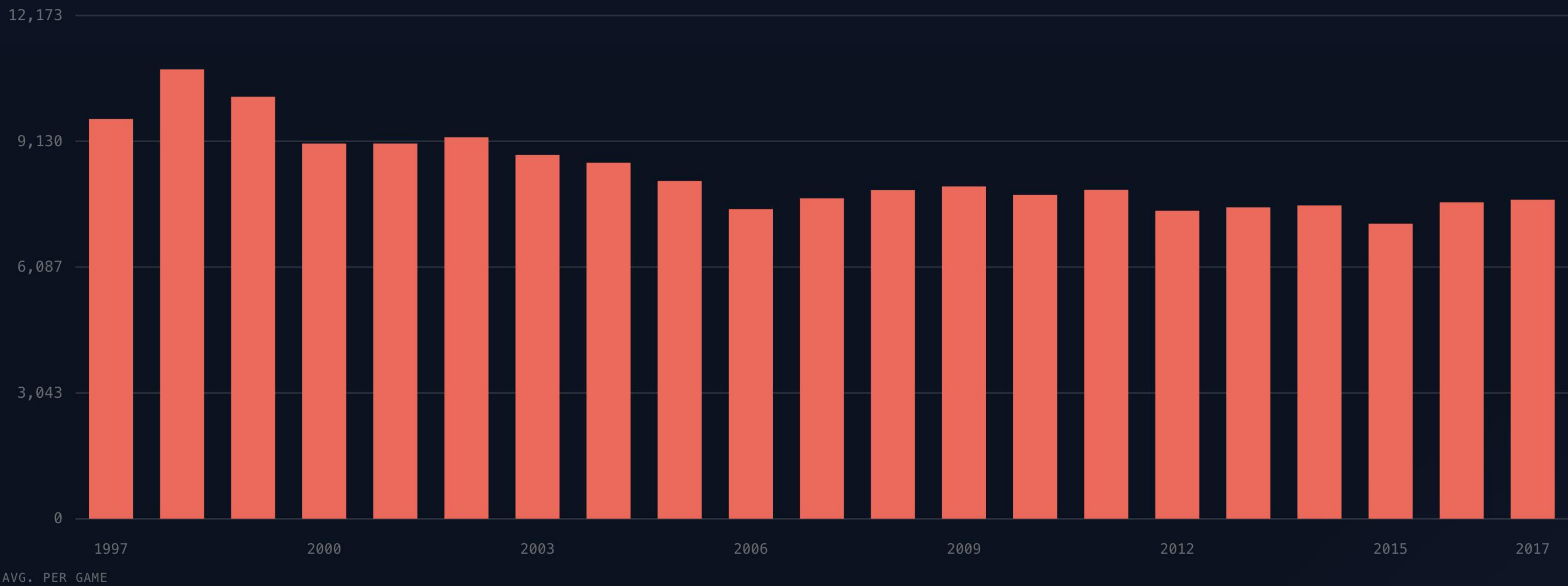
Revenue



Source – sportsvalue.com.br – NBA surpasses MLB, becomes world's second-richest league at US\$14B; NFL remains on top at US\$23B

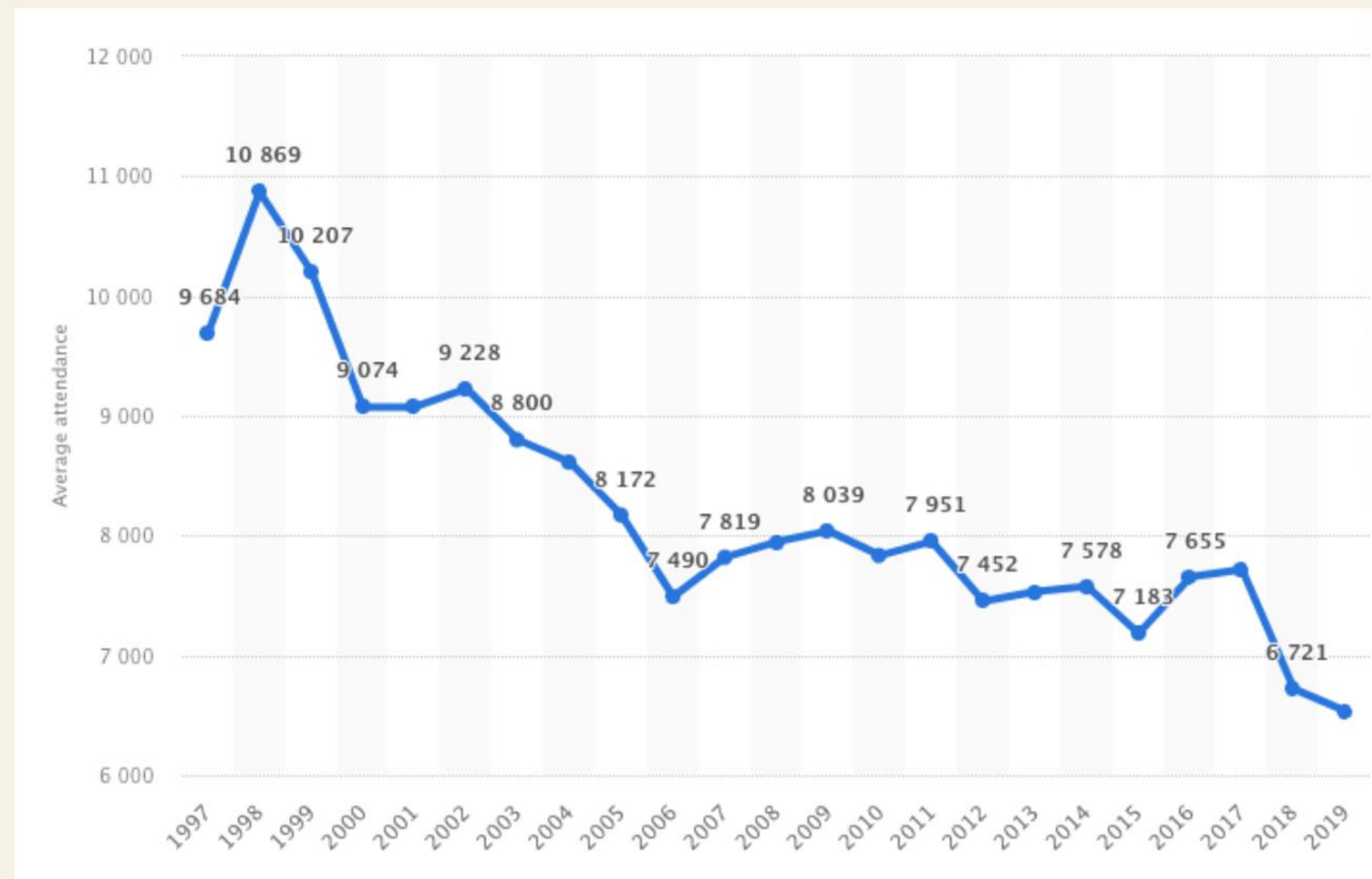
Attendance

- *How about for WNBA and the MLS (next slide)? Predict where attendance will go from here. Are there any concerns?*



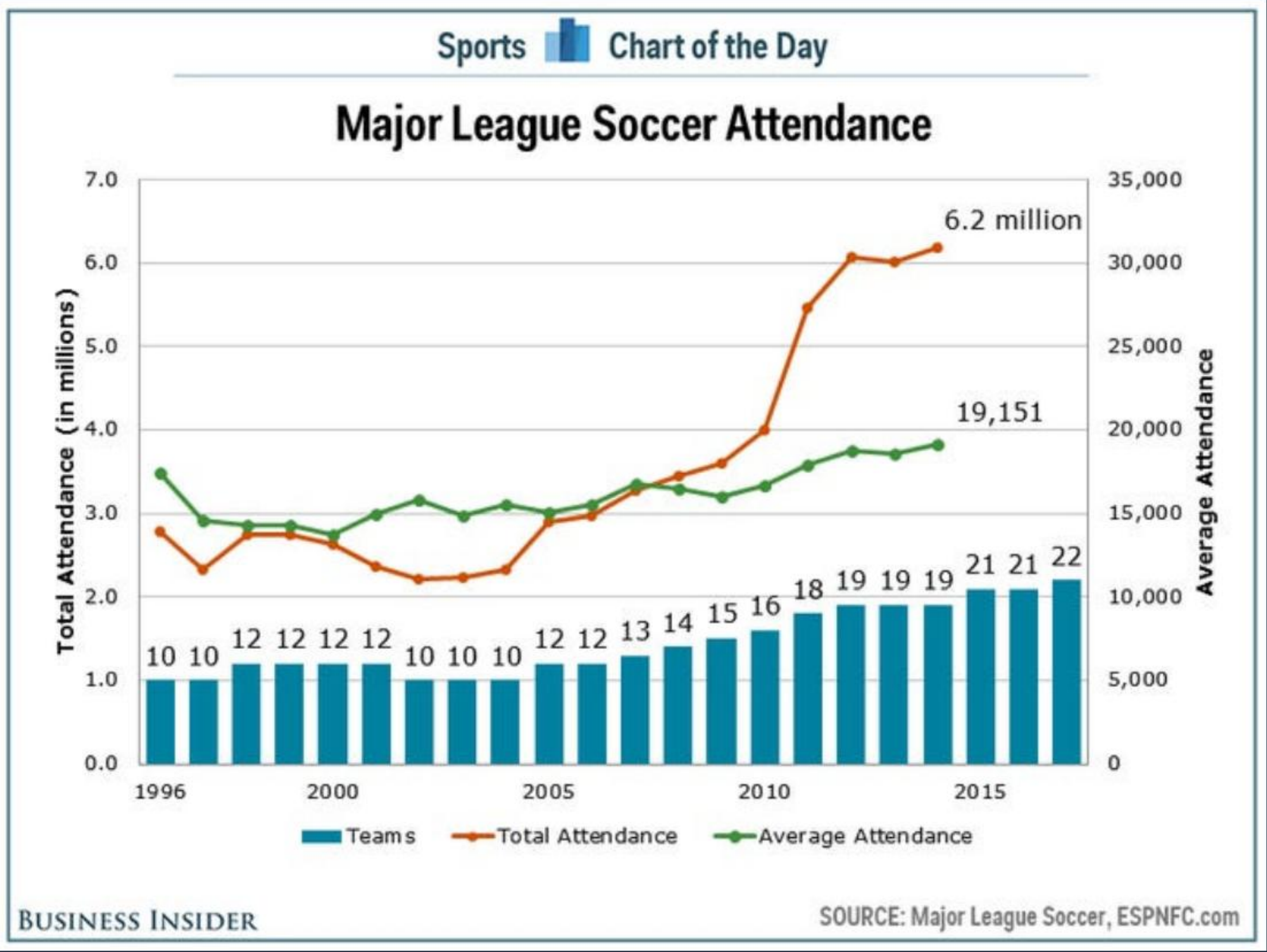
Attendance

- Now you may see the problem clearly.
- Updated attendance info is provided in a later slide.



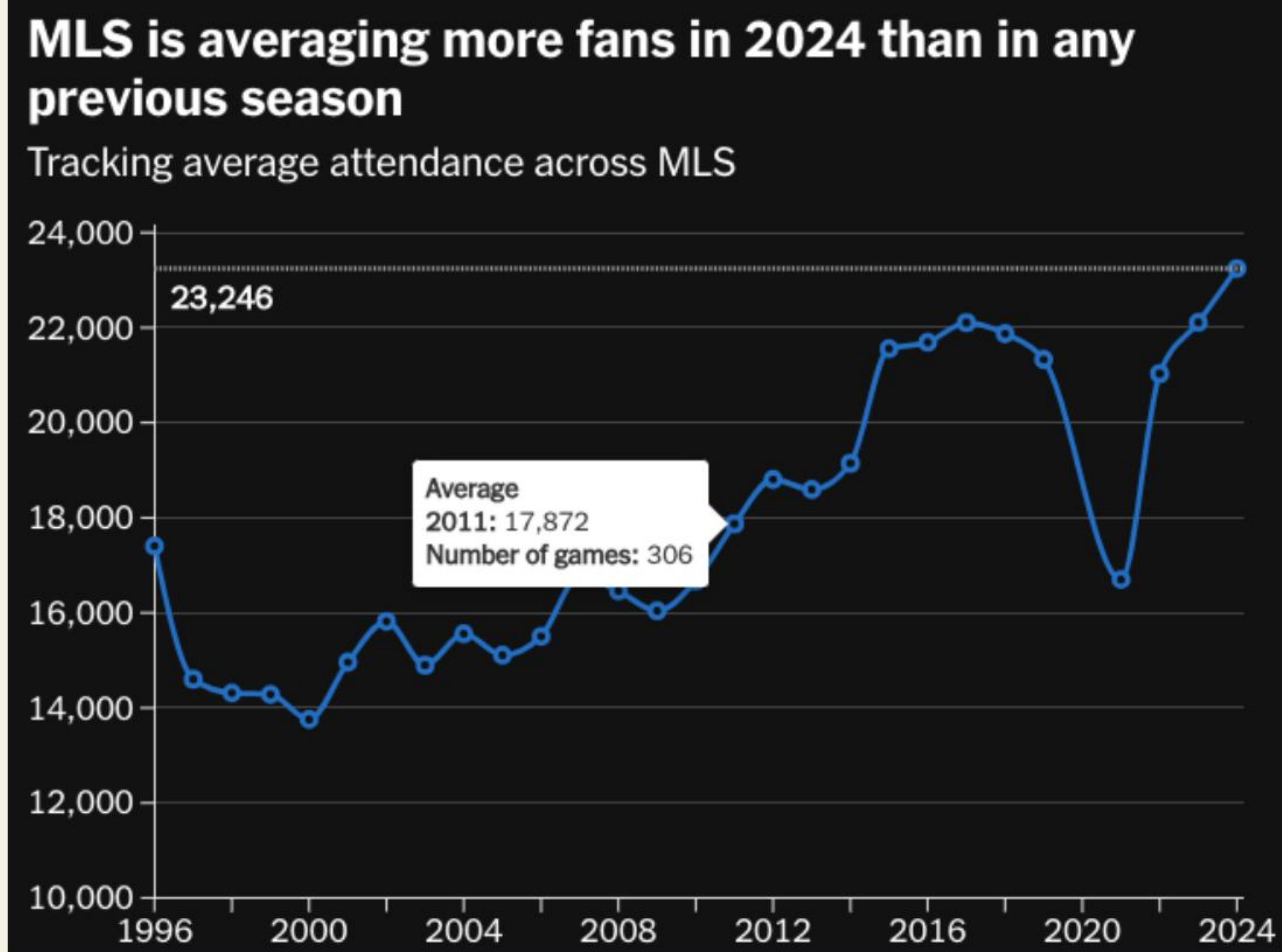
WNBA Attendance – Avg. per Game

Attendance



Attendance

- *Is this all because of the Messi effect or popularity of soccer?*
- The year-to-year growth is anchored by upward trends for 25 of the league's 29 active franchises (30 teams in 2026). Nine teams are currently averaging attendance at 100 percent of their stadium's capacity. Additionally, five matches have featured an attendance of 60,000 or higher in 2024, the most through this date in league history.





MLS MOMENTUM CONTINUES AHEAD OF 2026 FIFA WORLD CUP

**MLS EXPERIENCING THE STRONGEST THREE-YEAR
PERIOD OF FAN GROWTH IN LEAGUE HISTORY.**

**2026 MLS REGULAR SEASON HIGHLIGHTED BY 62%
VIEWERSHIP GROWTH AND RECORD-SETTING ATTENDANCES**

ATTENDANCE

- **4.8 million total fans** have attended MLS matches through the first three months of the season, the second highest in league history.
- MLS matches through May have **averaged 22,109 fans per match**, ranking second in MLS history.
- Three matches **surpassed 72,000 fans** this season, each ranking among the **top 10 largest crowds in MLS history**.

DIGITAL

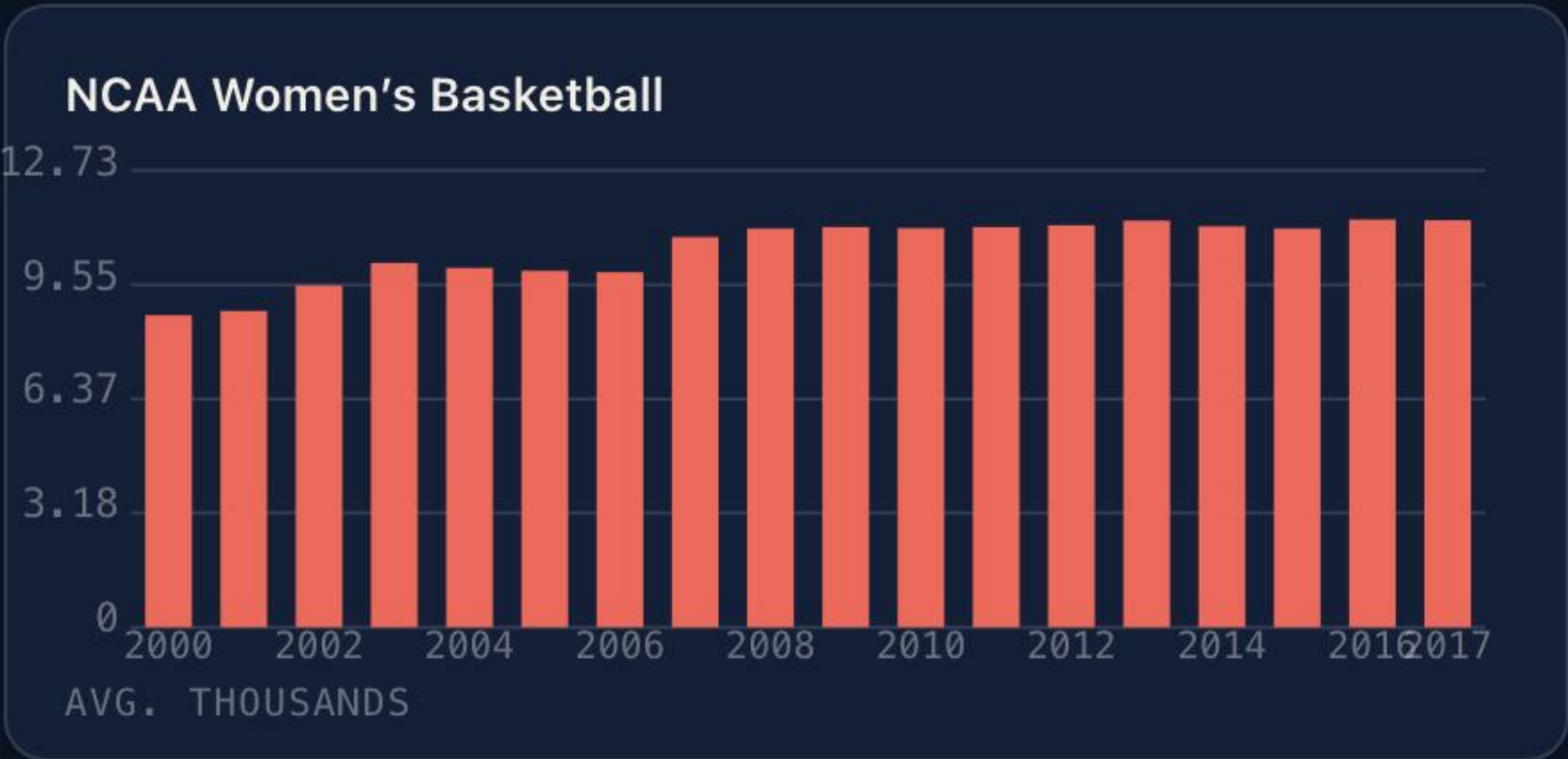
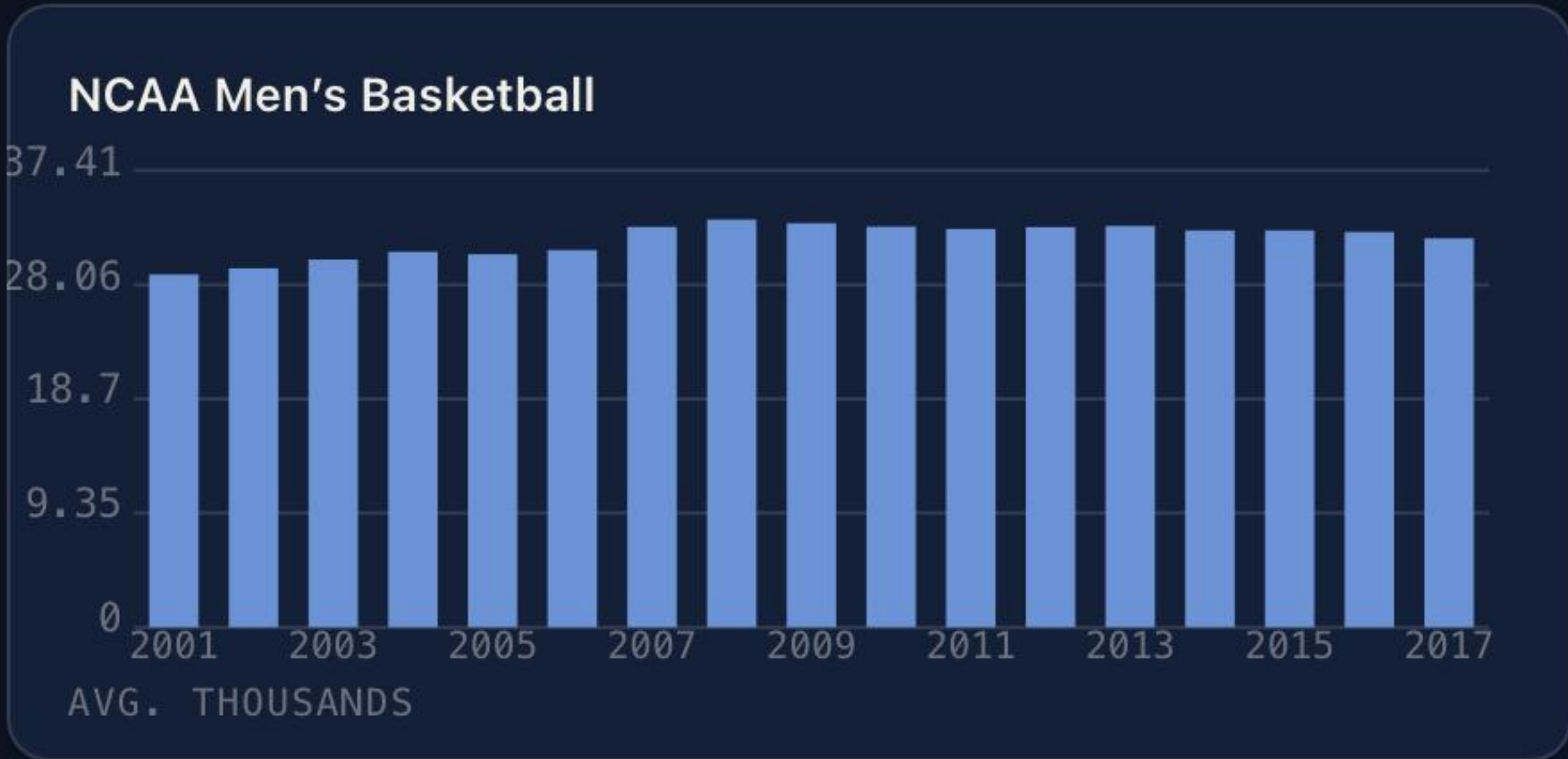
- **113 million followers** across MLS and club social channels, a **14% YoY increase**.
- **5.71 billion impressions** generated by MLS and club social accounts across Instagram, Facebook, TikTok, YouTube, and X, a **17% increase and highest since 2021**.

VIEWERSHIP

- **7.9 million live match viewers per week** across streaming and linear platforms through the first three months of the year, a **62% increase YoY**.

NCAA Attendance

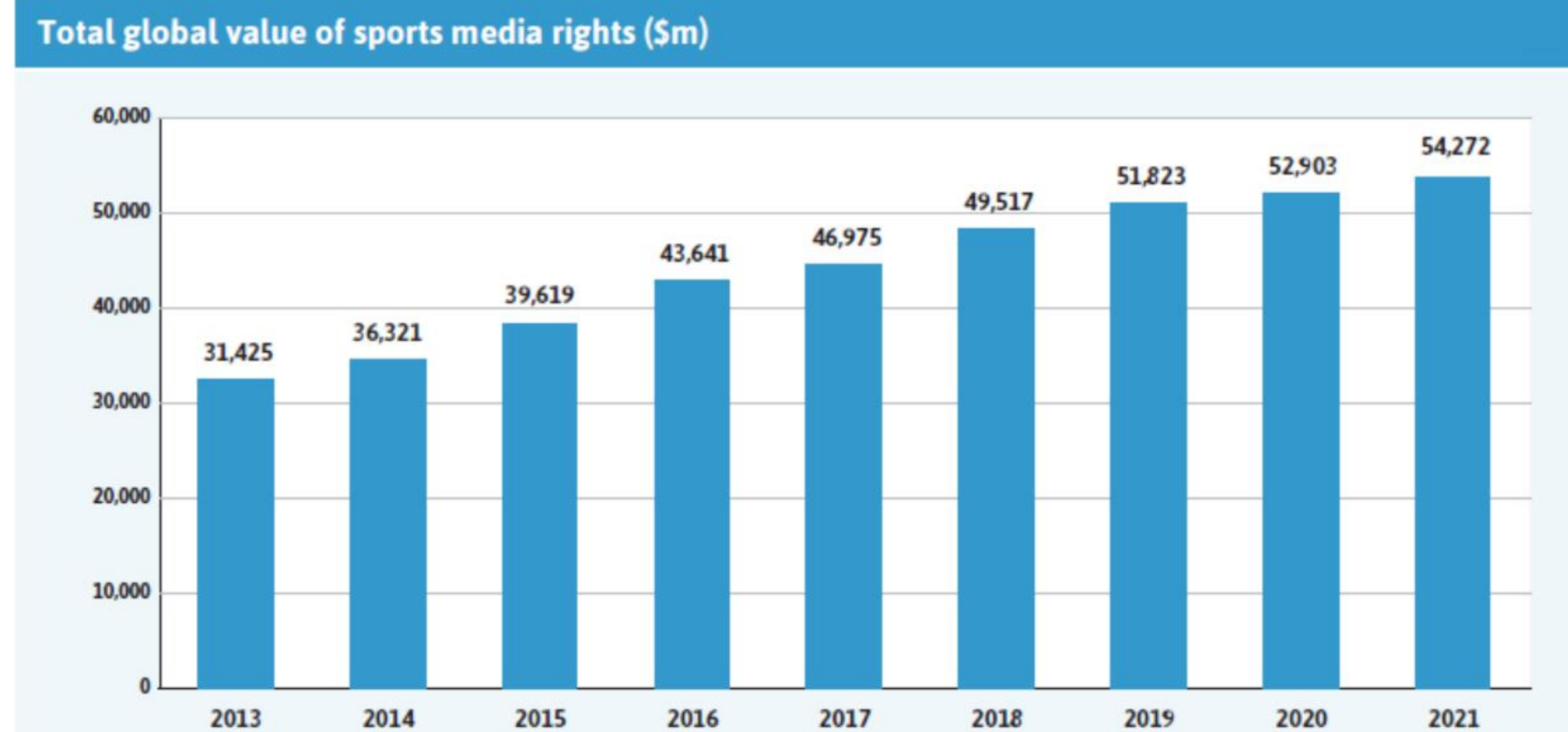
- *What are your predictions and should athletic dept. marketers have any concerns?*



Source – cbssports.com – college football attendance sees increase in consecutive seasons for first time since 2008

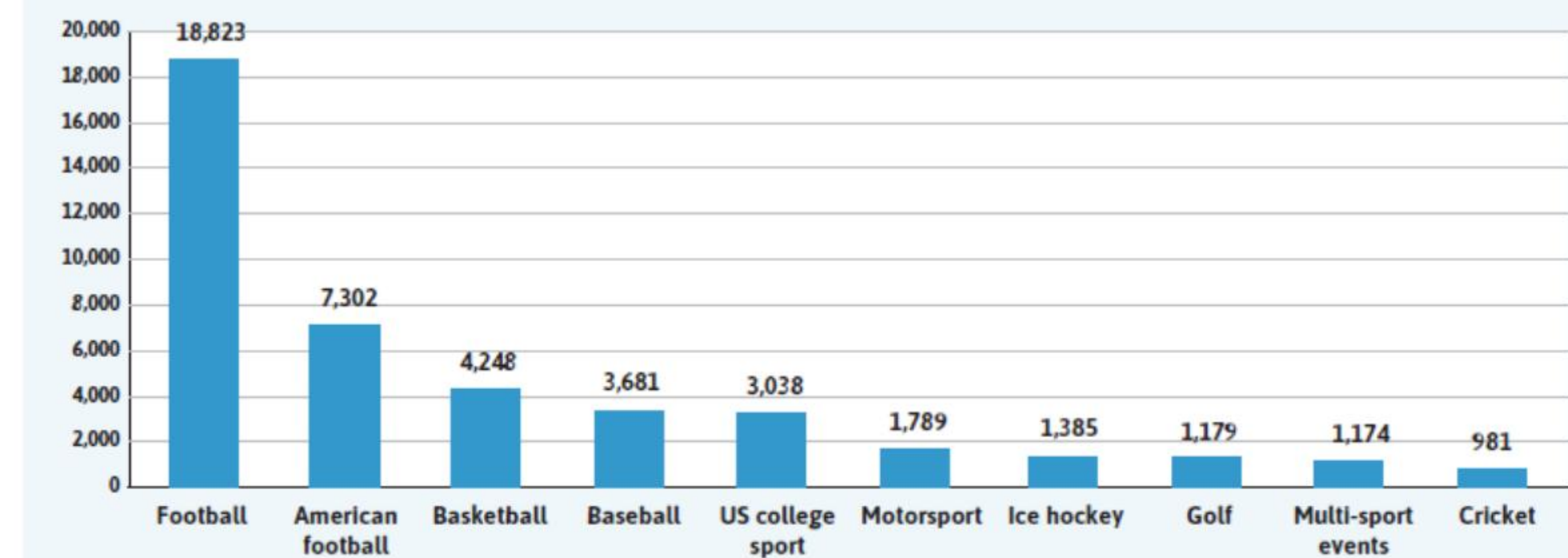
Media Rights

- *What do these graphs tell us? Any concerns for sport marketers?*



Source: TV Sports Markets

Top 10 sports by global media rights value 2017 (\$m)



Source: TV Sports Markets

Media Consumption

74%

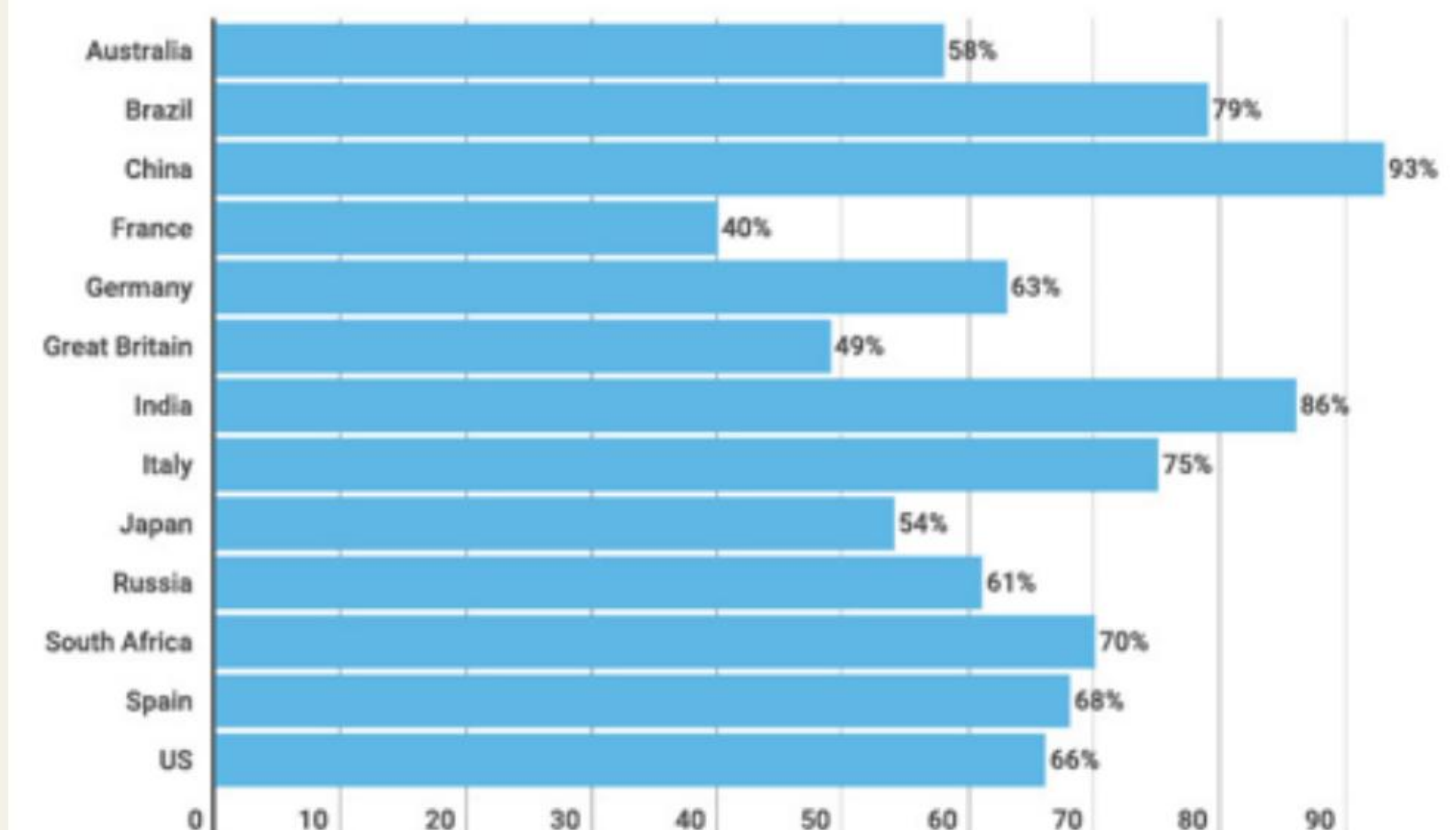
still pay for TV subscriptions

49%

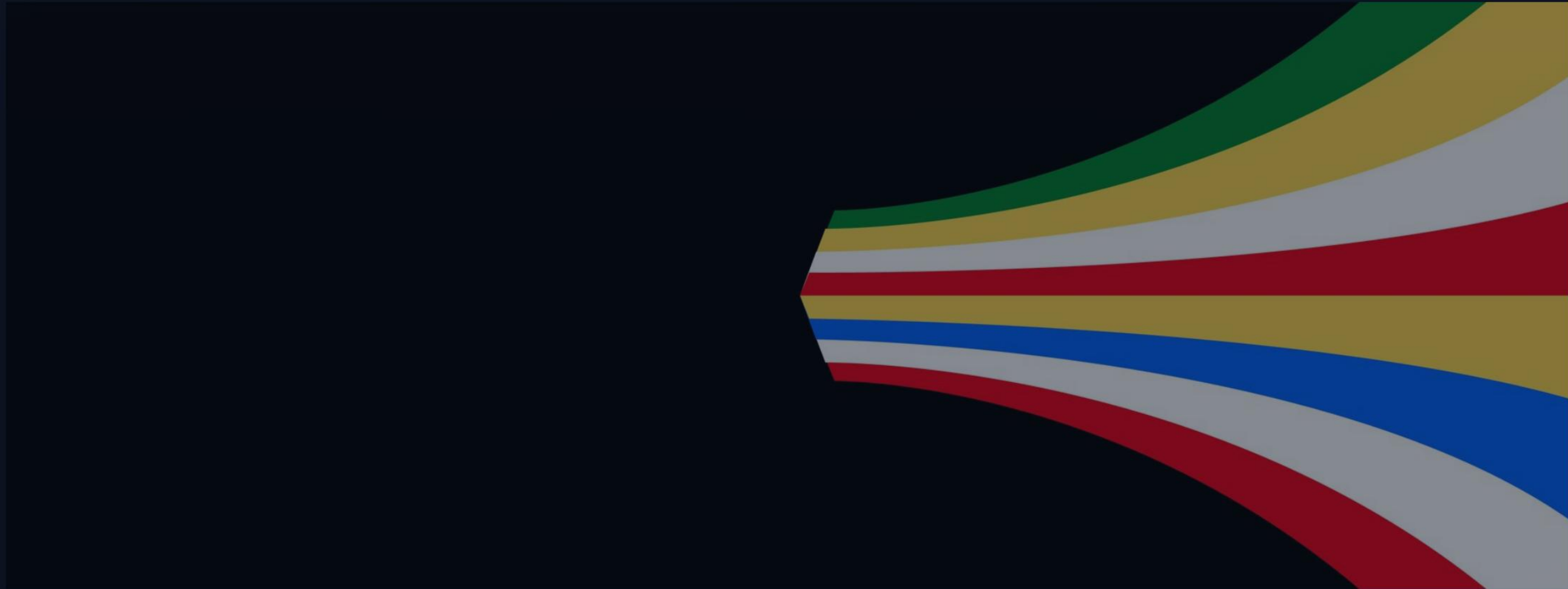
now pay for a streaming service

- 74% of U.S. consumers continue to pay for TV subscriptions.
- 49% are now paying for a streaming service.
- The amount of time spent watching content on a smartphone though has increased from 58 minutes per day in 2014 to 2:10 hours in 2016.
- *Are these potential issues for sport organizations?*

Percentage of sports fans that consume sport by smartphone



IBM Study: Sports Fans Demand More Dynamic Digital Content, Powered by AI



Source – 2025 Study – newsroom.ibm.com/2025-08-18-ibm-study-sports-fans-demand-more-dynamic-digital-content,-powered-by-ai

IBM Study: Sports Fans Demand More Dynamic Digital Content, Powered by AI

Sports engagement expands beyond the game with fast, non-stop content across screens

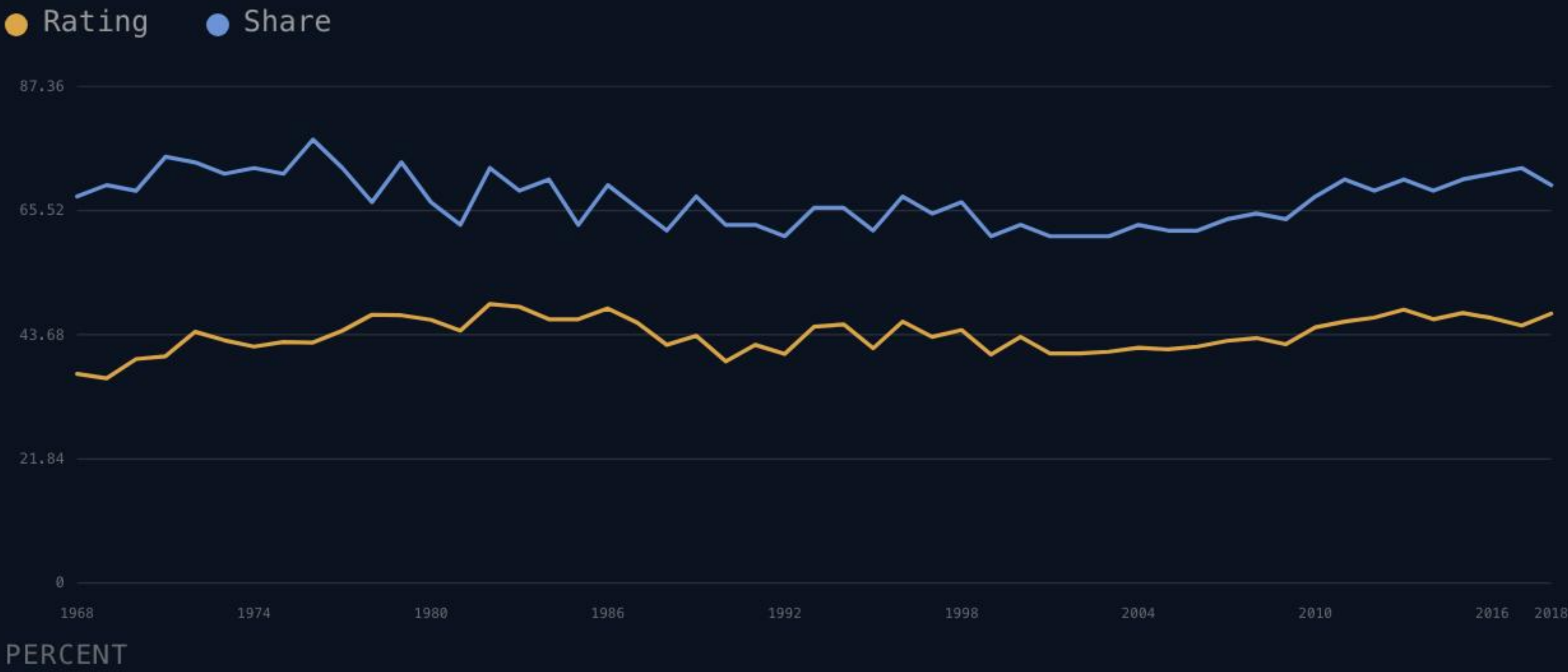
- Most (90%) fans surveyed consume sports content beyond watching events, with younger fans leading the trend.
- 40% of surveyed mobile sports app users rely on apps for centralized information and 35% for real-time updates when unable to watch games live.
- About 1 in 5 F1, golf, and tennis fans use apps tailored to their favorite sports.
- Mobile sports app usage jumps among in-person event attendees, with 82% of surveyed fans using apps during events. Of those, 91% engage with apps during live events, mostly for real-time commentary (44%), stats or analytics (41%) and enhanced in-stadium experiences (35%).
- Among fans surveyed in both 2024 and 2025, multi-device usage to follow sporting events increased from 27% to 29%, indicating a significant upward trend in second-screen behavior.
- 74% of respondents following sports influencers say storytelling is important to how they experience or connect with sports, especially among fans ages 18-44.

Rating vs. Share

- *Which is a better measure of how popular the sport or event is? Why?*
- *Or should we just use viewership numbers instead?*
- The rating is the percentage of the nation's TV sets that are tuned in to the game.
- The rating share is the percent of the TV sets which are turned on and are tuned to the game.

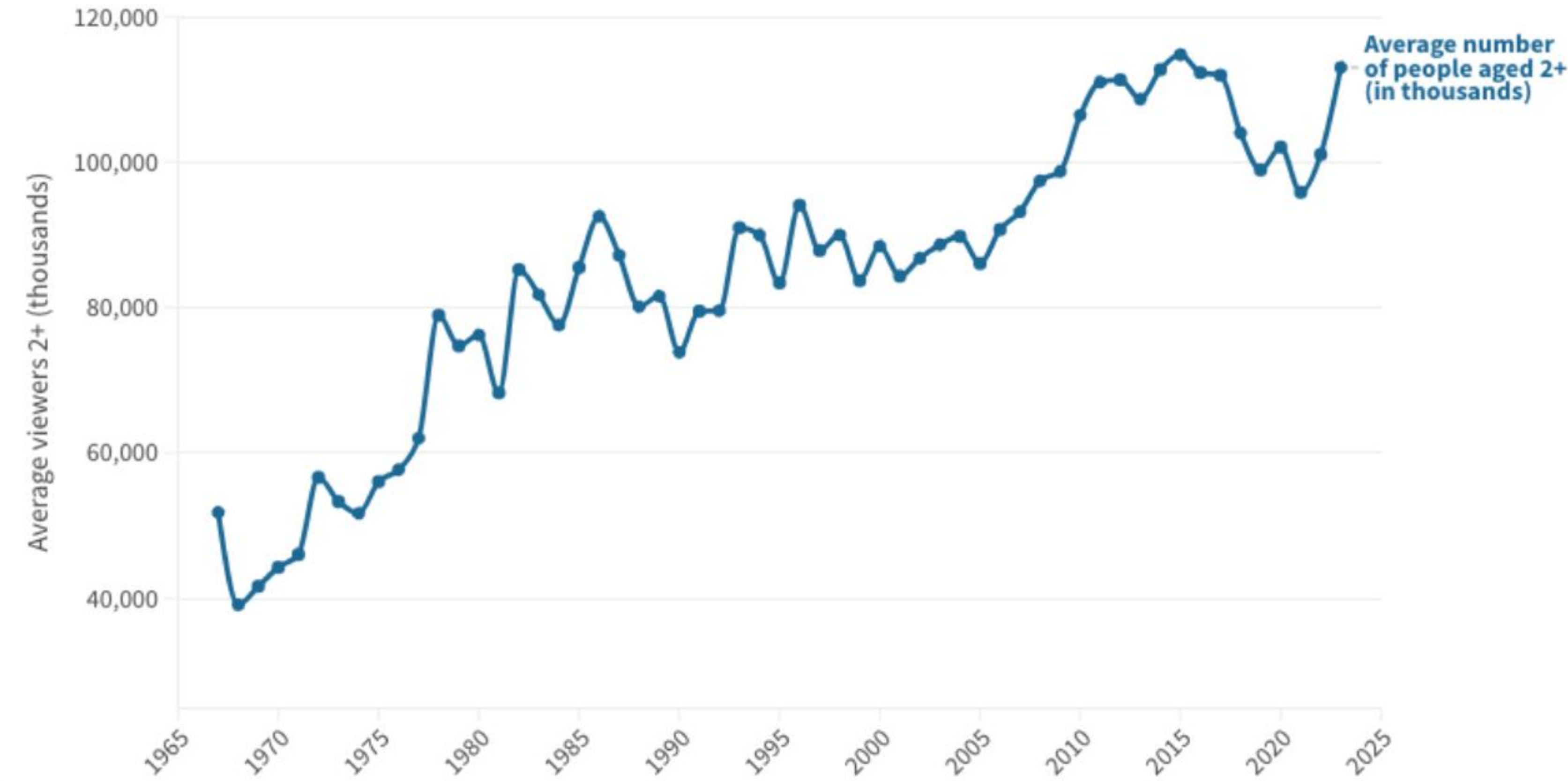


How come the number of viewers for the Super Bowl keeps increasing but the ratings and share do not?



Super Bowl viewership by year

Super Bowl 49 in 2015 currently holds the record with 114,810,000 viewers

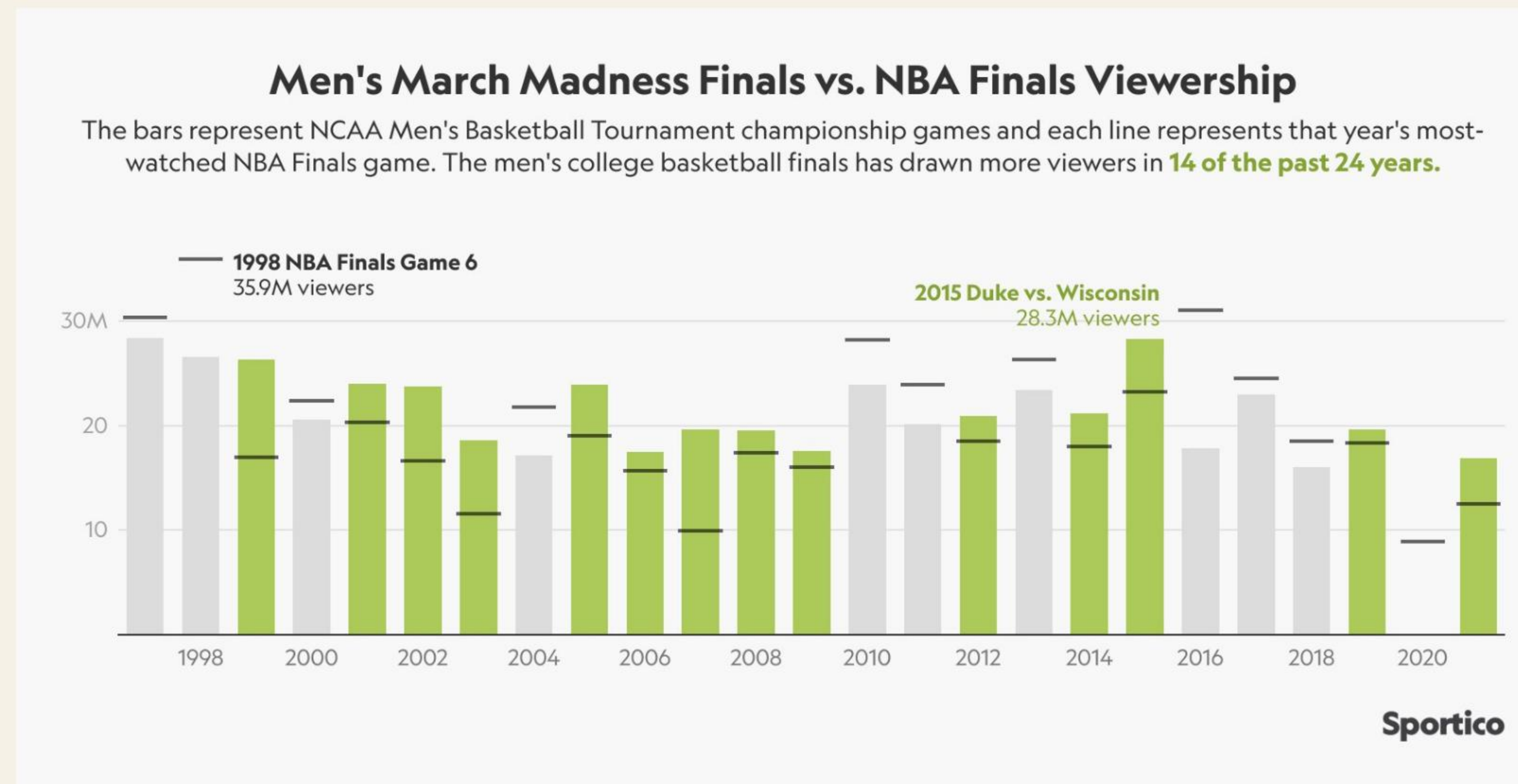


Super Bowl viewership by year

While a show's rating is the percentage of all possible TV households or viewers in the country, its share is the percentage of households or viewers actually watching TV at the time.

Media Consumption

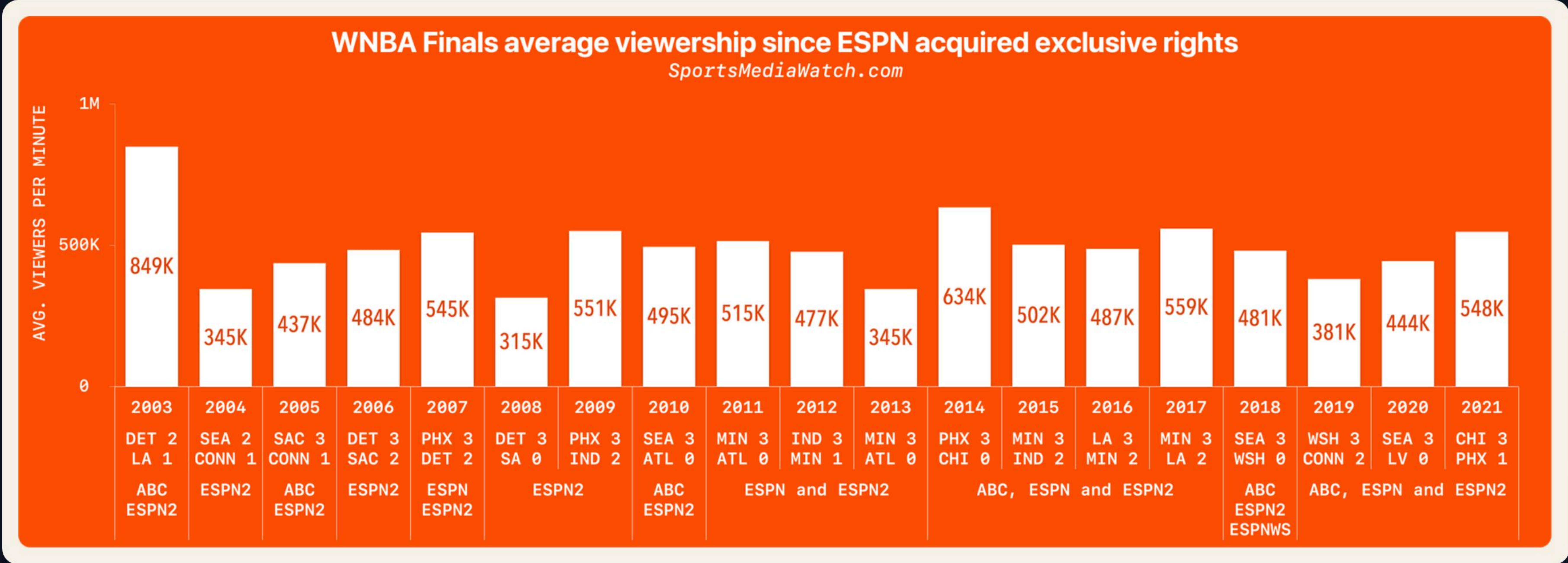
- *What is happening with the NBA Final's viewership numbers and why you think that this is happening. Where will they go from here?*



Source — forbes.com/sites/mollybohannon/2024/06/18/nba-finals-hit-lowest-viewership-in-3-years/

WNBA

- *What about WNBA viewership and ratings? Why do you think they are like they are and what do you think will happen in the future?*
- *What can WNBA sport marketers do to help?*



WNBA cont.

- Caitlin Clark's debut nets WNBA's highest ratings since 2001 with 2.12m viewers
- WNBA TV ratings: Caitlin Clark helps WNBA reach historic mark, 18 games over 1 million viewers
- Weeks after an uproar over Caitlin Clark not being named to Team USA, the Indiana Fever rookie and her fellow stars received overwhelming support for the WNBA All-Star Game



WNBA cont.

- The WNBA averaged 11,127 fans per game in the first half of the season, up 15.3% over the same period last season, according to an SBJ analysis of WNBA data. The league is on pace to draw a record 3.18 million this season, which would shatter last year’s record of 2.35 million and double the 2023 total.

TEAM	TOTAL ATTENDANCE	NO. OF GAMES	AVG. ATTENDANCE	CHANGE FROM FIRST HALF OF 2024
Golden State Valkyries	198,704	11	18,064	N/A
Indiana Fever	218,696	13	16,823	-2.0%
New York Liberty	193,245	12	16,104	30.5%
Los Angeles Sparks	131,474	11	11,952	8.7%
Las Vegas Aces	112,259	10	11,226	0.7%
Seattle Storm	134,380	12	11,198	4.9%
Phoenix Mercury	126,664	12	10,555	1.0%
Minnesota Lynx	117,612	12	9,801	9.5%
Chicago Sky*	95,600	10	9,560	9.6%
Connecticut Sun*	93,842	10	9,384	24.6%
Dallas Wings*	81,850	11	7,441	22.9%
Washington Mystics**	59,283	10	5,928	-11.9%
Atlanta Dream*	49,743	11	4,522	-2.5%
League	1,613,352	145	11127	15.3%

2025 WNBA Mid-Season Attendance

11,127

fans per game, first half of season

15.3%

up over the same period last season

Media Consumption

- *What impact does this info have on sport marketers?*

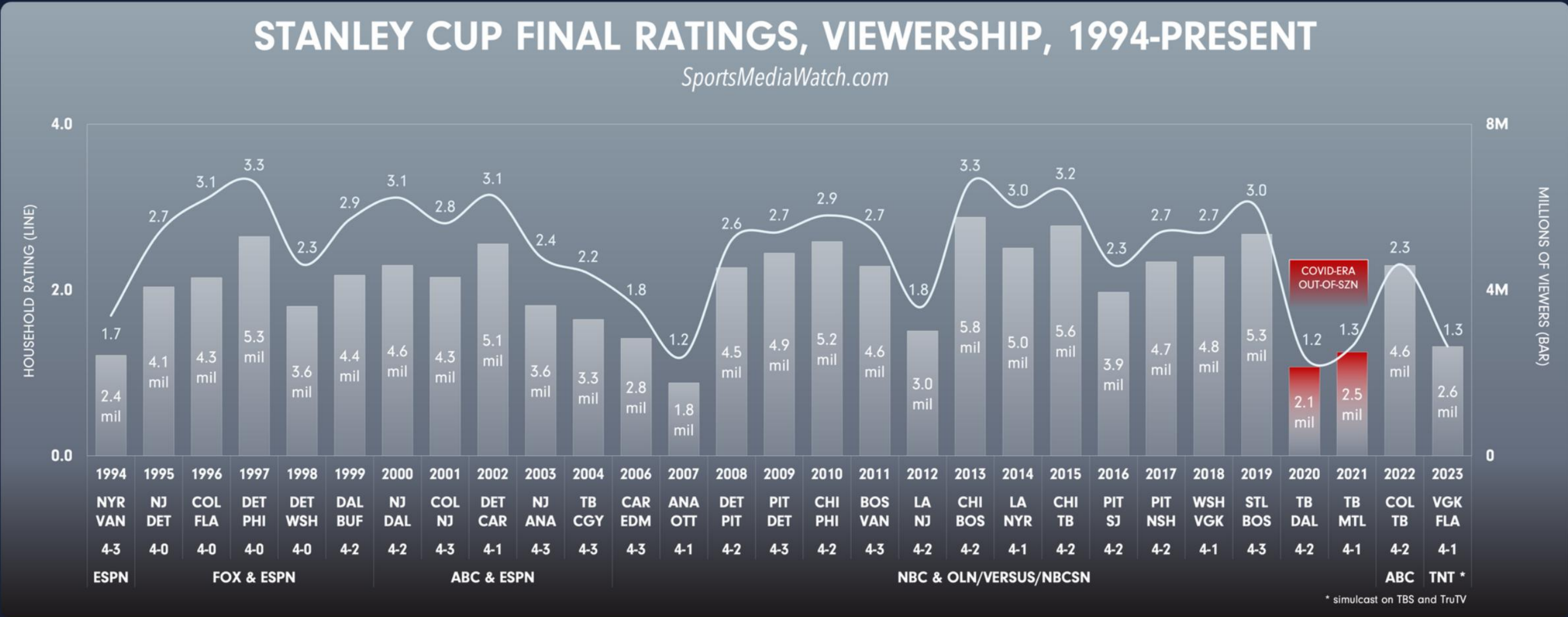
WORLD SERIES AVERAGE RATING, VIEWERSHIP

Past 30 years



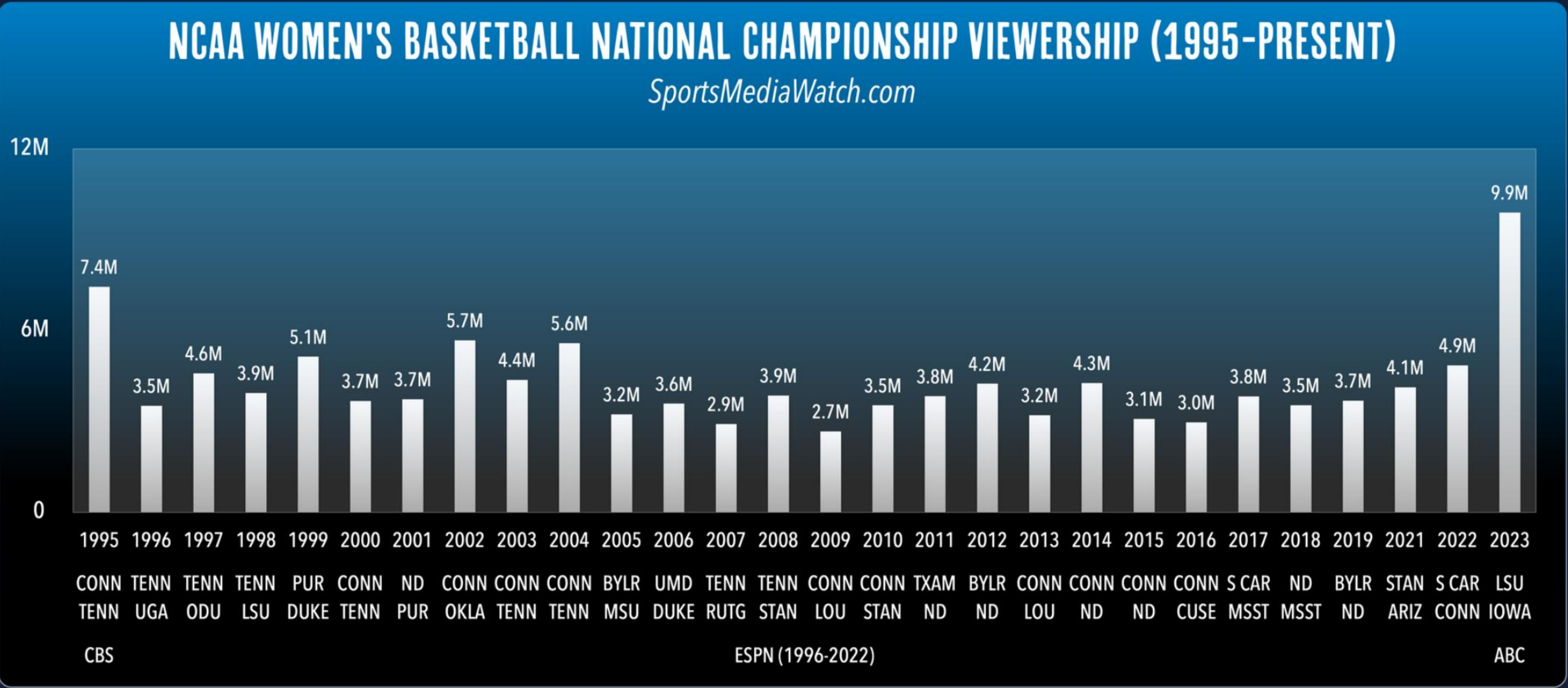
Media Consumption

- *What impact does this info have on sport marketers?*



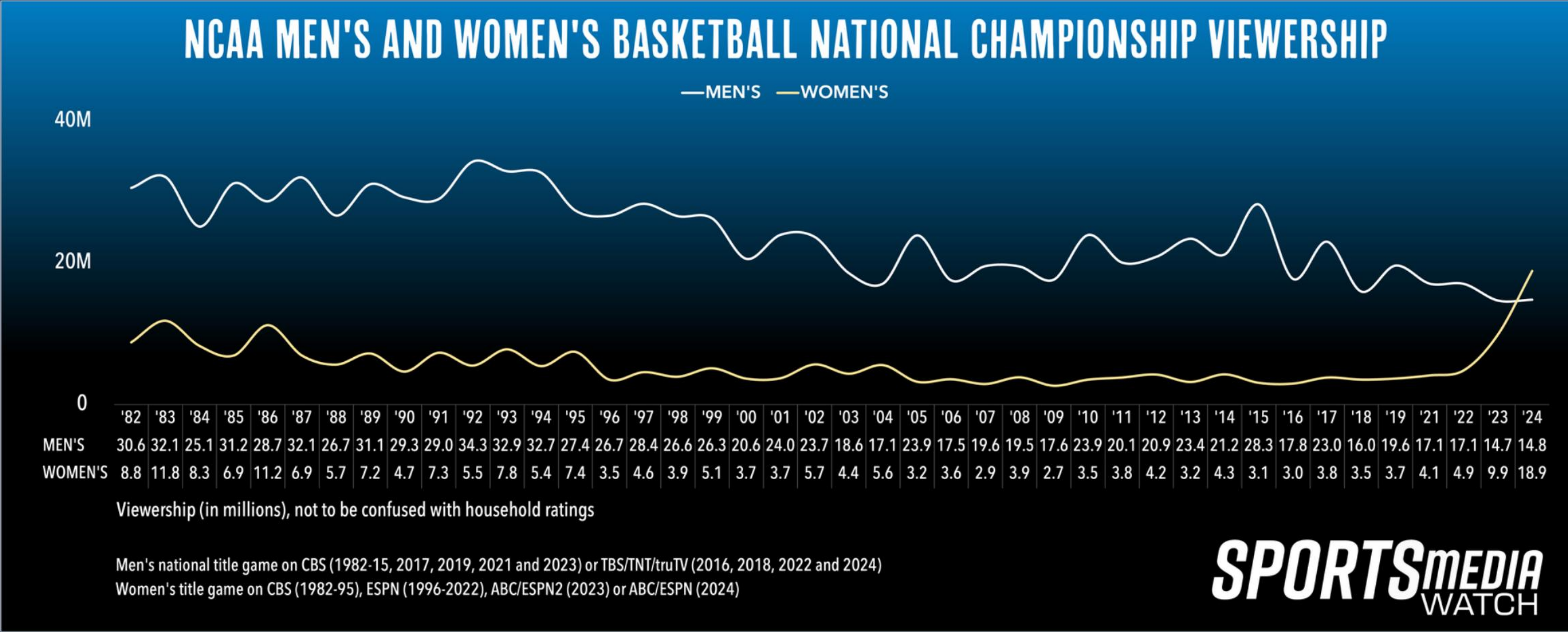
NCAA Television Ratings

- *What implications might these ratings have for athletic departments?*



NCAA Television Ratings

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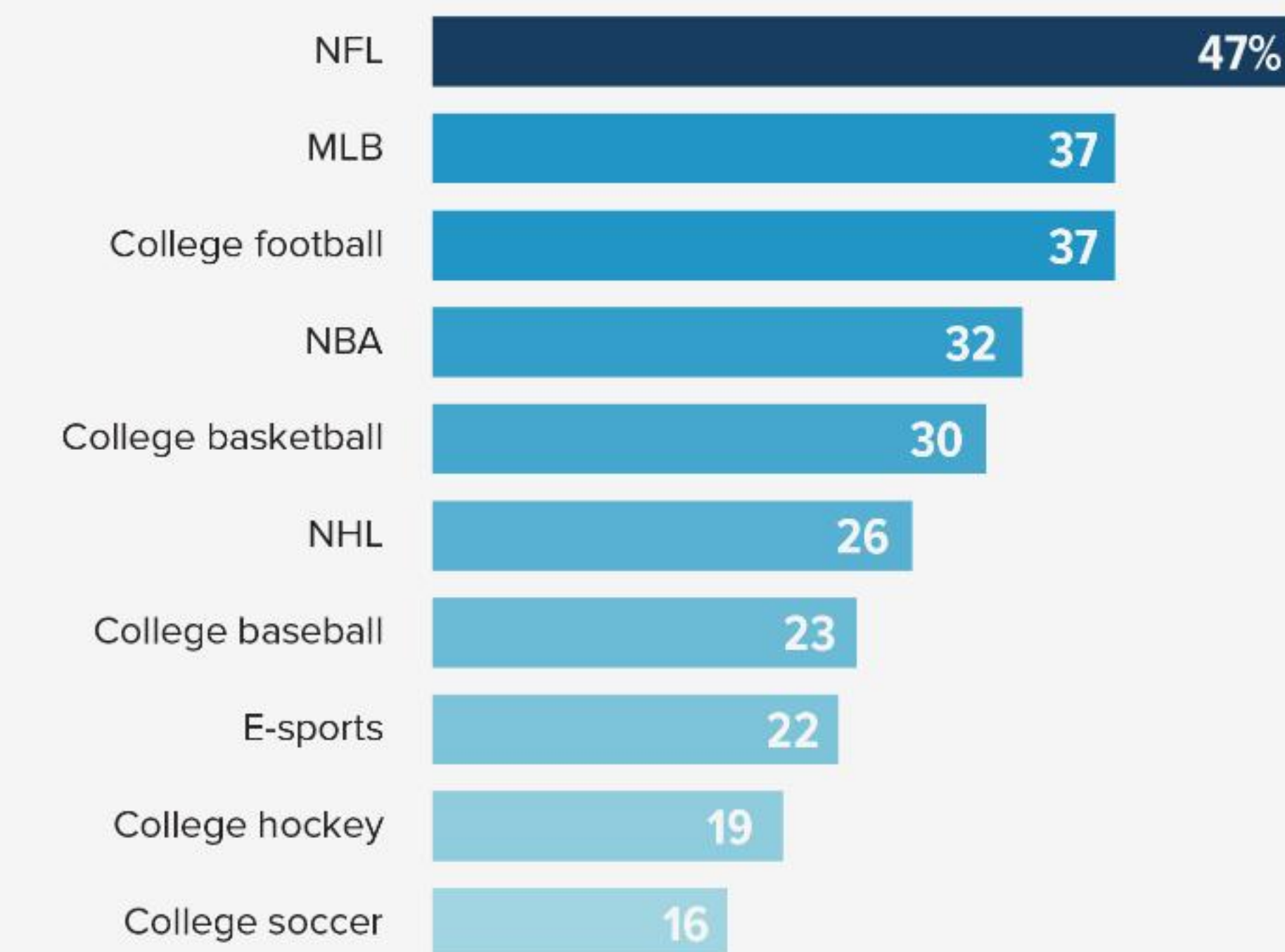


Livestreaming

- *What do you think will happen with livestreaming sports in the future?*
- *Will it vary by sport? Why or why not?*
- *What relevance does this have for sport marketers?*

Livestreaming Makes Americans More Likely to Watch Sports, Especially the NFL

Americans who said they would be more likely to watch each sport if a social media company livestreamed it:



MORNING CONSULT

Media Consumption

- Gen X – Born between 1965 and 1982ish.
- Millennials – Born between 1983ish and 2000ish. Also known as Gen Y.
- *What does this graph tell us?*
- *Why should sport marketers care?*

Percentage of total millennial and Gen X sports fans

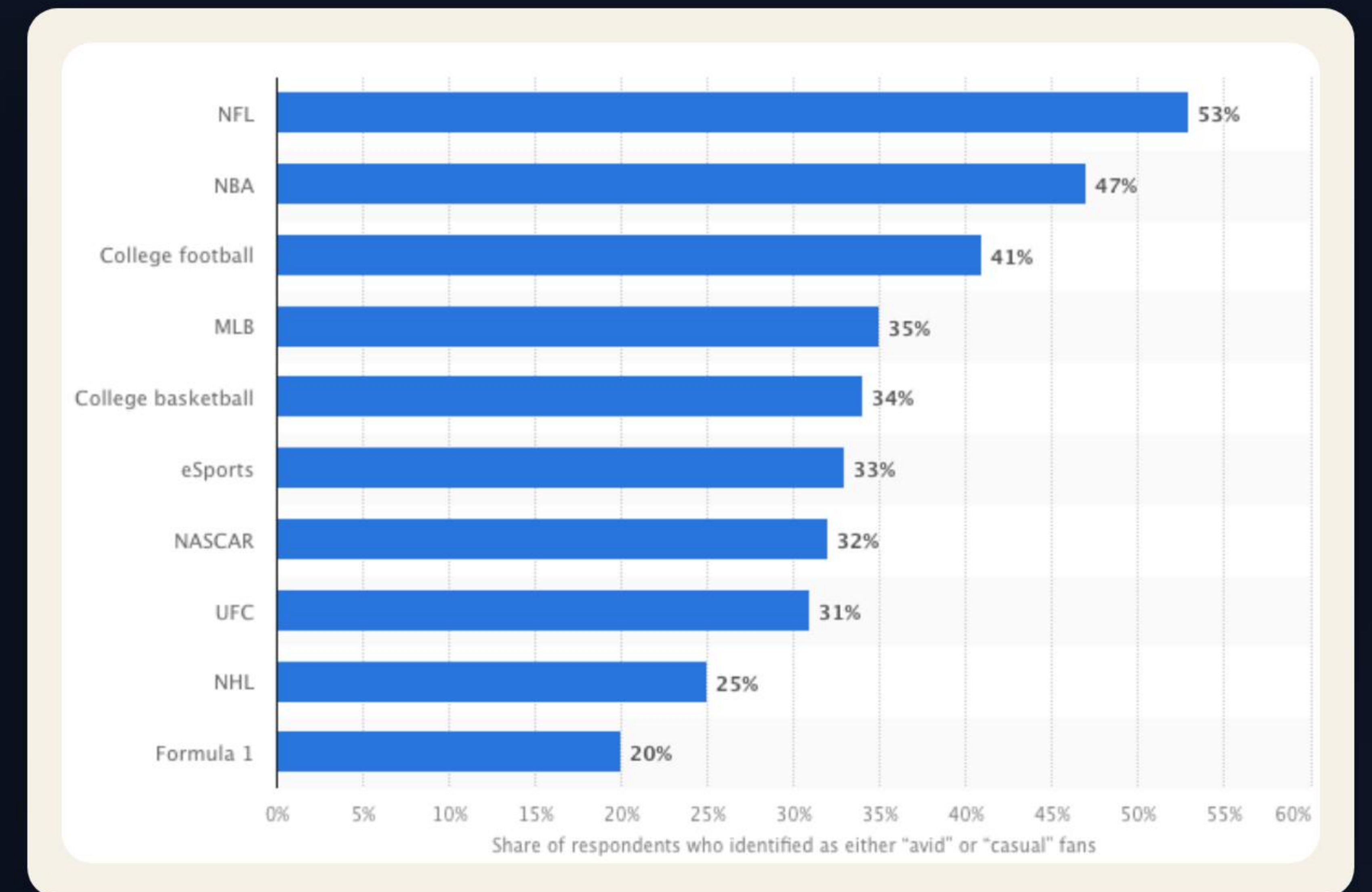
	Watching highlights		Checking scores and news updates	
	Millennials	Generation X	Millennials	Generation X
Uses at least one of ESPN, NBC, CBS, or FOX	45%	44%	52%	54%
ESPN sites and app	37%	32%	43%	42%
NBC sites and app	6%	8%	7%	7%
CBS sites and app	6%	8%	7%	15%
FOX sites and app	8%	10%	12%	13%
Uses at least 1 social-media platform	67%	50%	60%	40%
Facebook	40%	31%	36%	29%
YouTube	42%	18%	12%	9%
Twitter	20%	10%	20%	9%
Instagram	18%	3%	14%	3%
Snapchat	9%	2%	10%	1%
Reddit	1%	1%	2%	0%

McKinsey&Company | Source: McKinsey online survey, n=465, June 2017

Media Consumption

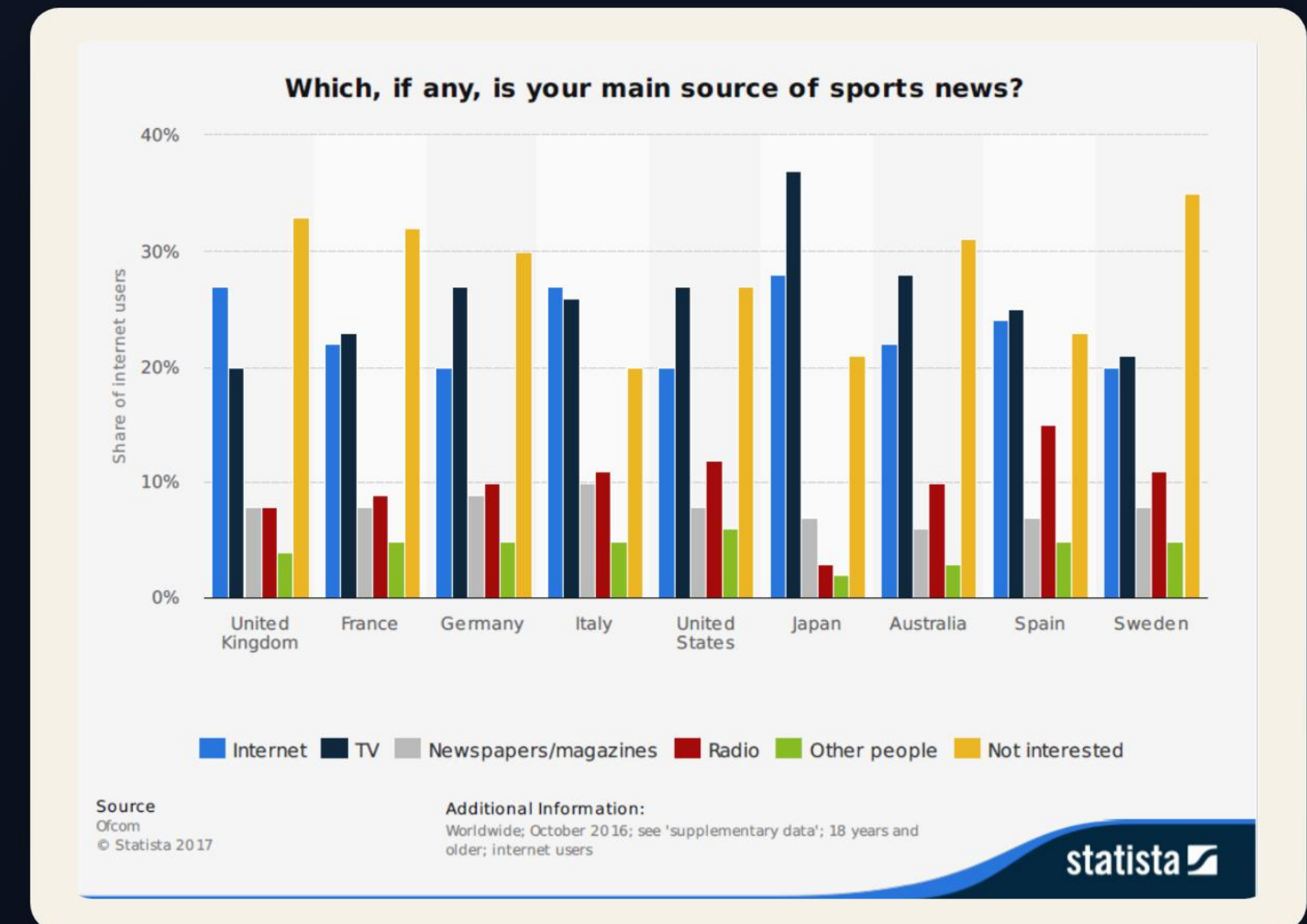
Most Popular Sports Among Gen Z in US

- Gen Z (born 1997-2012)
- Nine in ten Gen Z sports fans use social media to consume content as consumption habits shift.



Media Consumption

- *What is important for marketers of different leagues to know, based on this graph?*



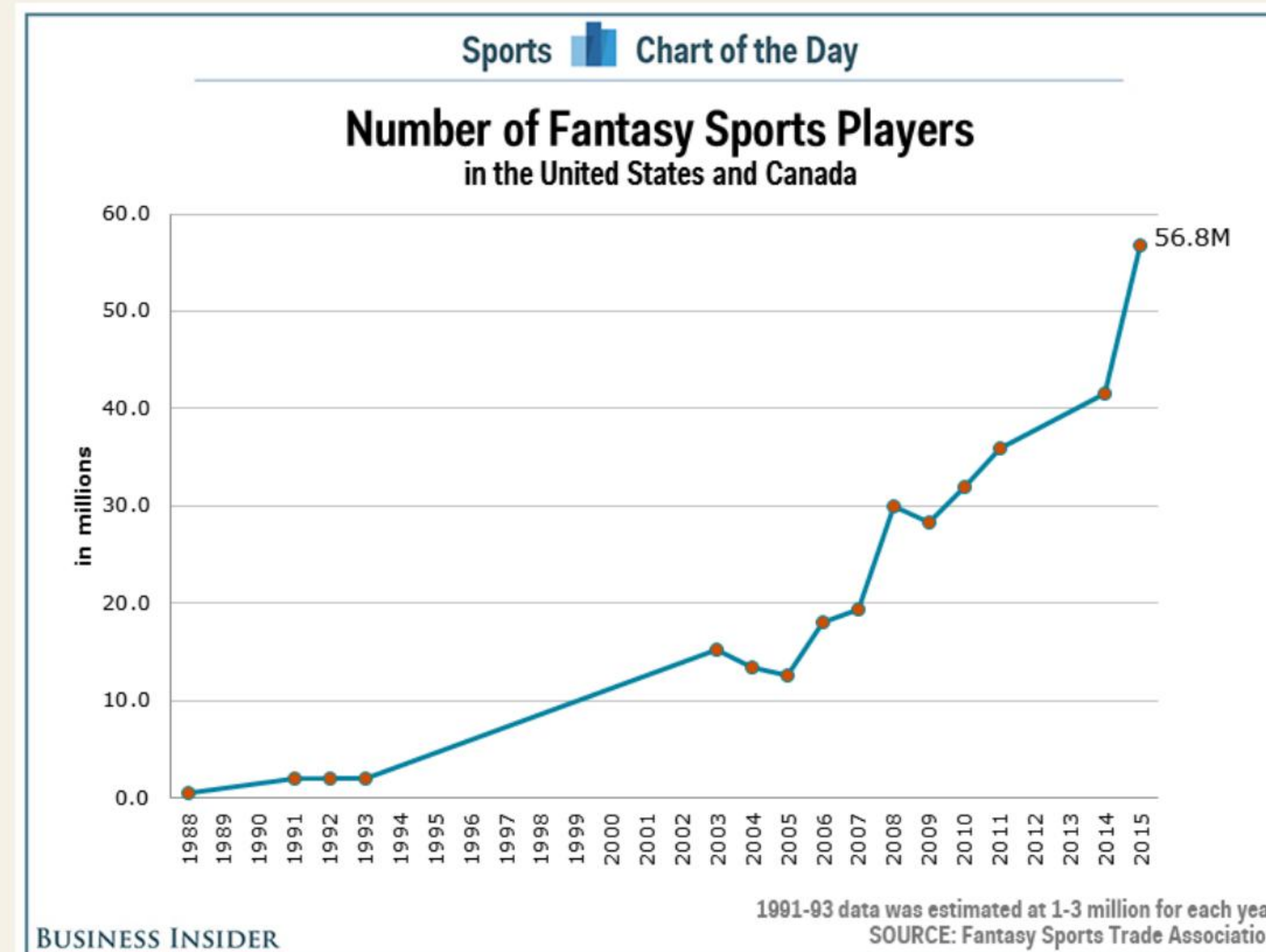
Social Media Consumption

- *Do you agree with the rankings in this table? Why or why not?*
- *What relevance does this info have for sport marketers?*

RANK	TEAM	FOLLOWERS (M)	INTERACTIONS (M)	MEDIA VALUE (US\$M)
1	FC Barcelona	145	1,450	\$25.30
2	Real Madrid	141	601	\$17.20
3	Manchester United	88.4	522	\$12.10
4	Arsenal	50.6	239	\$9.20
5	Chelsea	59.6	181	\$6.10
6	FC Bayern	46.8	204	\$2.50
7	Los Angeles Lakers	29.4	106	\$11.00
8	Golden State Warriors	13.6	293	\$3.30
9	Manchester City	27.5	107	\$5.80
10	Cleveland Cavaliers	9.5	102	\$12.50
11	Juventus	30.3	156	\$2.00
12	Liverpool	37.3	146	\$1.60
13	New England Patriots	10.9	88.4	\$4.30
14	Borussia Dortmund	18.8	91.4	\$1.90
15	Paris Saint-Germain	32.7	67.2	\$1.30

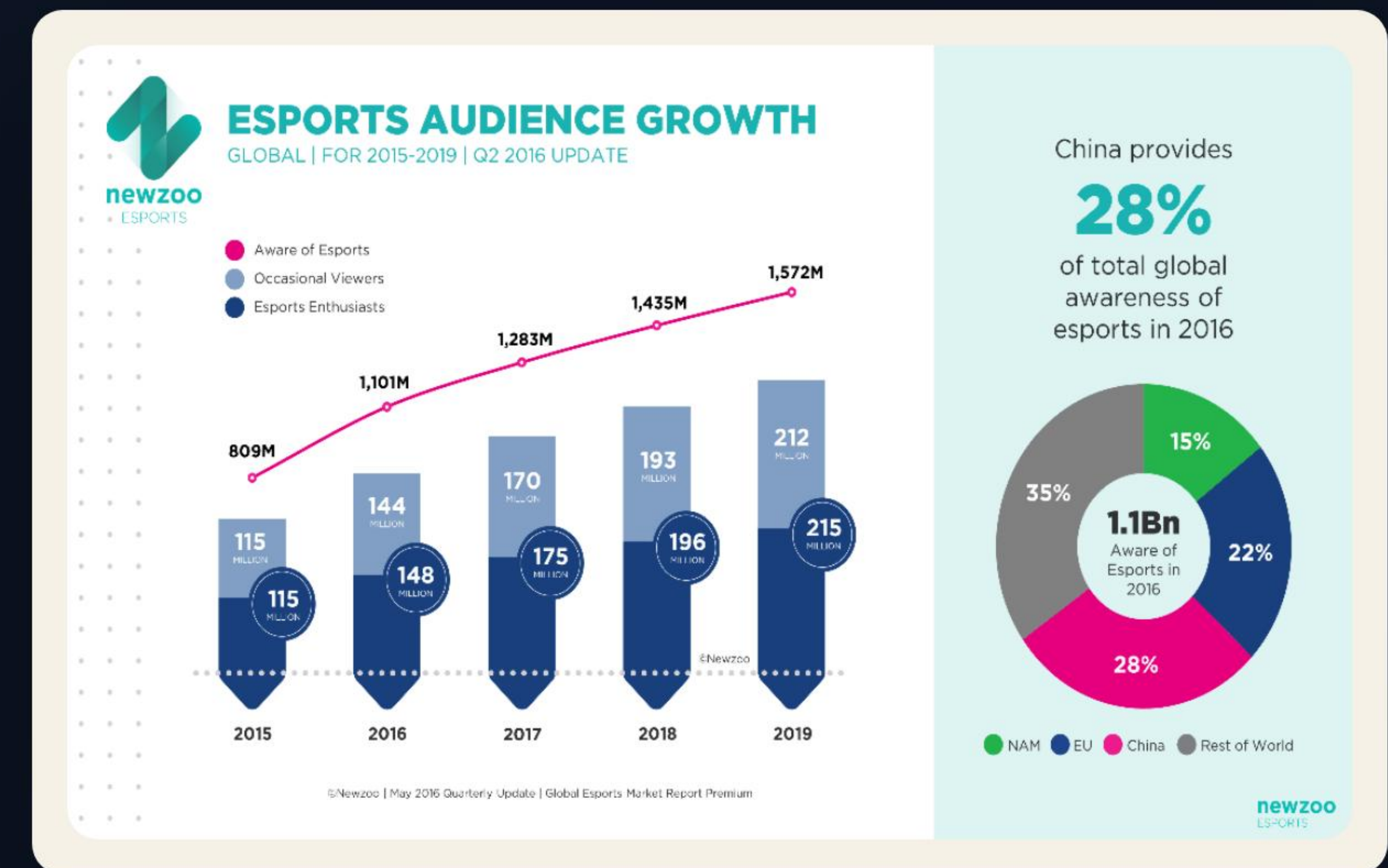
Fantasy sports

- *Based on the information in the chapter and on the internet, what do you think the future of fantasy sports is?*
- *Why should sport marketers care?*



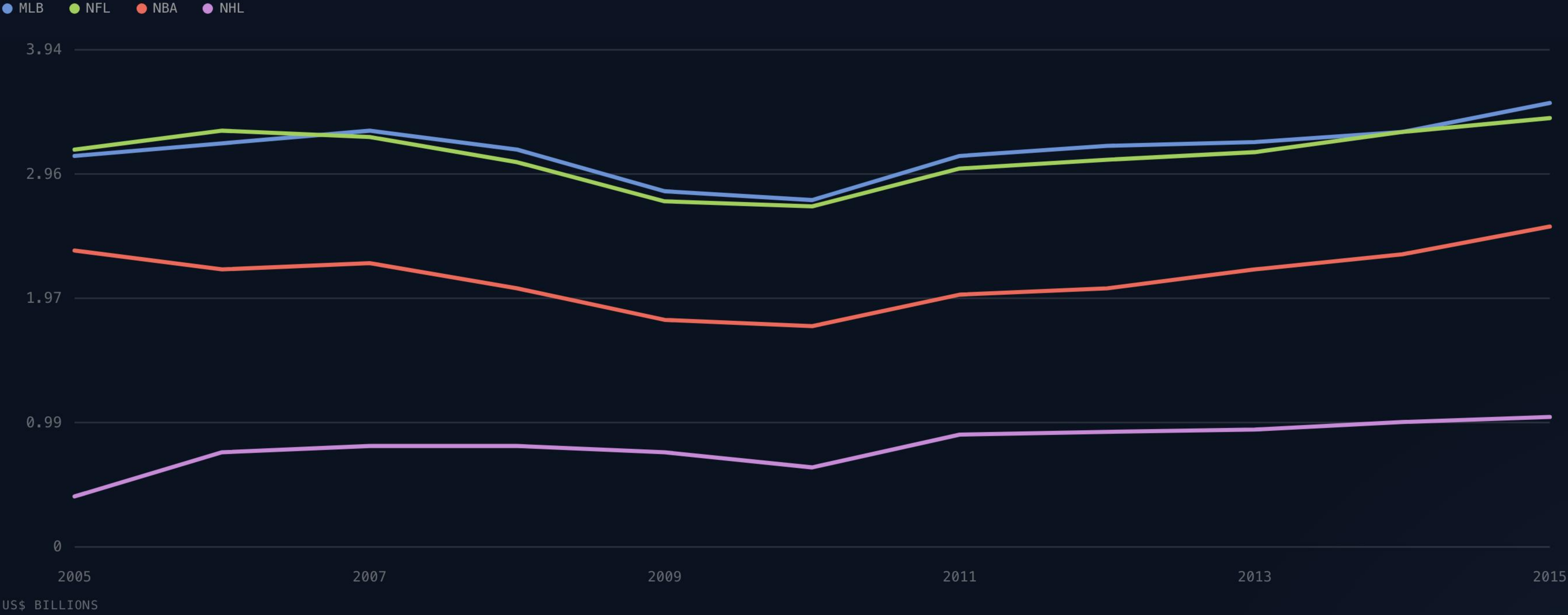
eSports

- *What predictions do you have about eSports?*
- *Why should sport marketers care about eSports at all?*



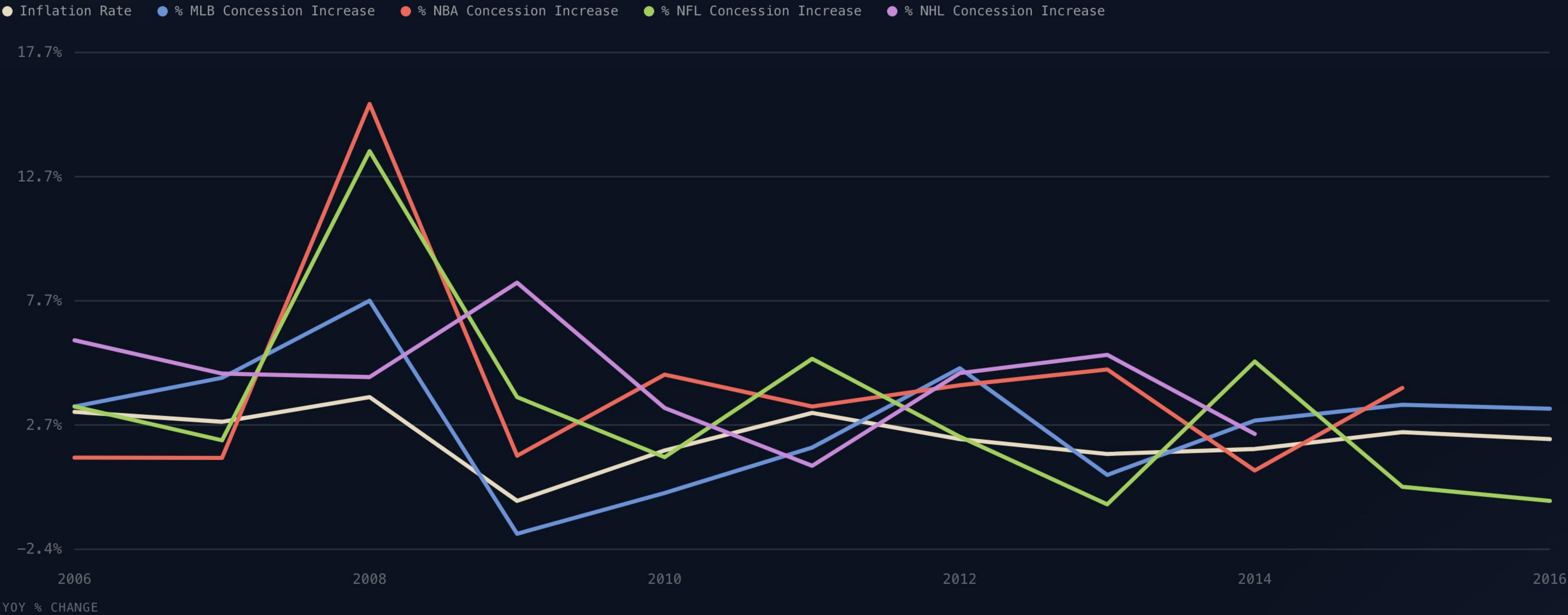
Retail Sales of Licensed Sport Merchandise

- *What do you think the future trends will be for sales of licensed merchandise? Why?*
- *What impact do sport marketers have on these trends?*



Concessions

• *What does this graph tell us and why is it important relative to consumer behavior?*



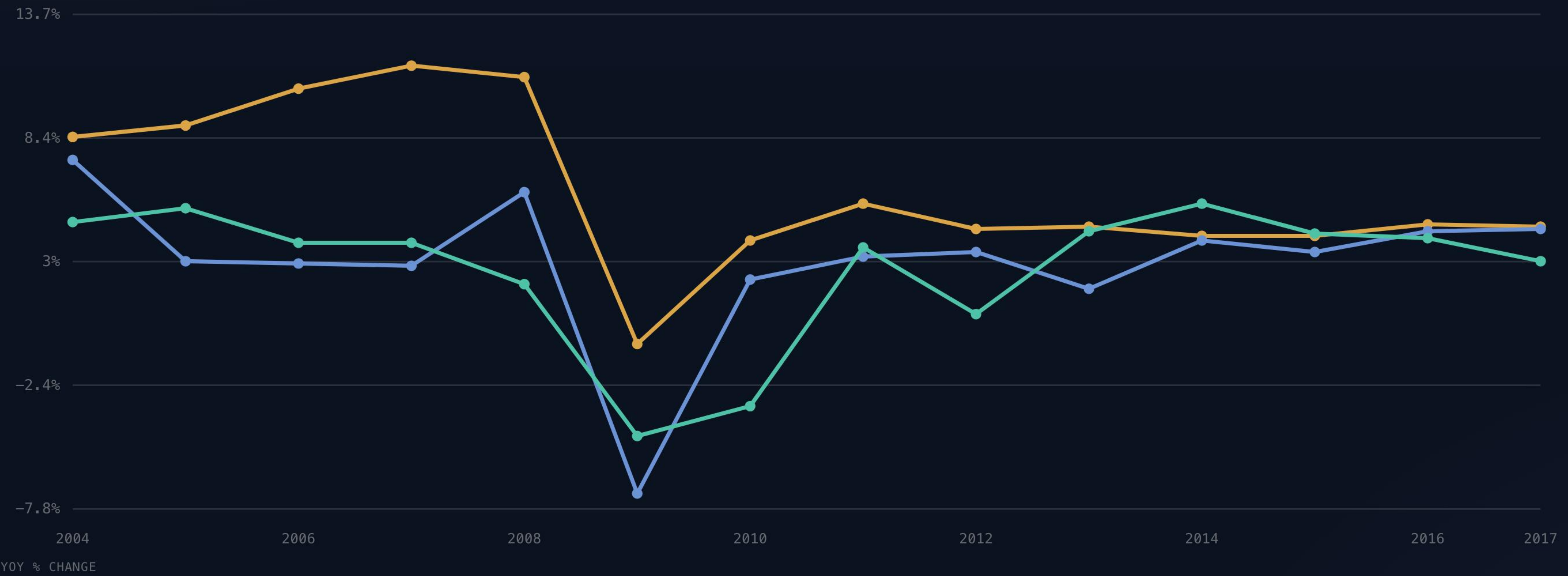
Corporate Partnerships

- *What relevance do corporate partnerships and naming rights have to the study of sport consumer behavior?*



• *What does this graph tell sport marketers?*

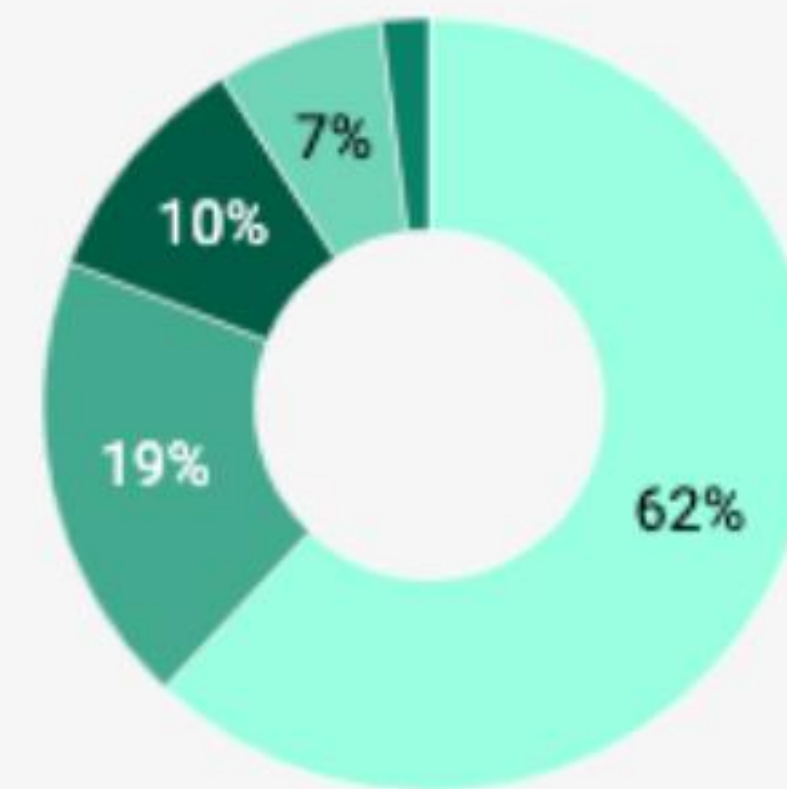
● Sponsorship ● Advertising ● Sales Promotion



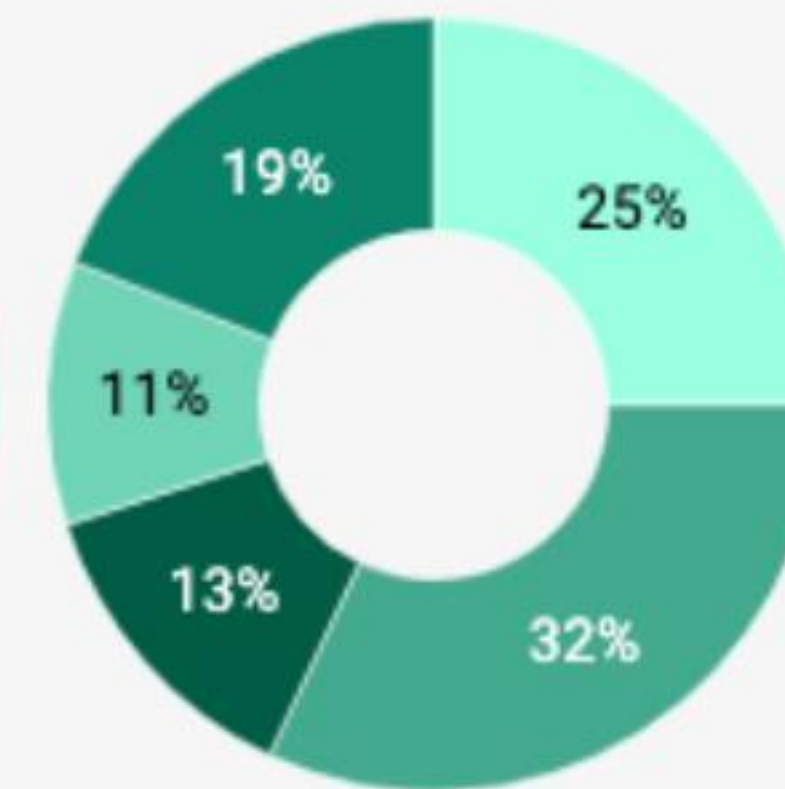
2025

Revenue breakdown of men's US sports leagues

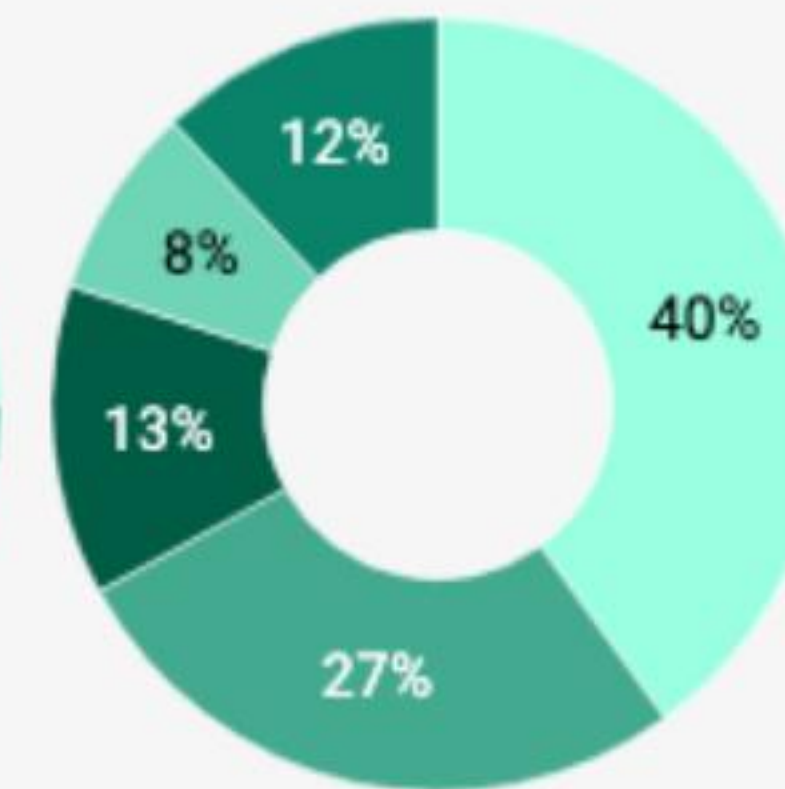
- National revenue
- Seating/suites
- Team sponsorships
- Concessions/parking/other
- Local media



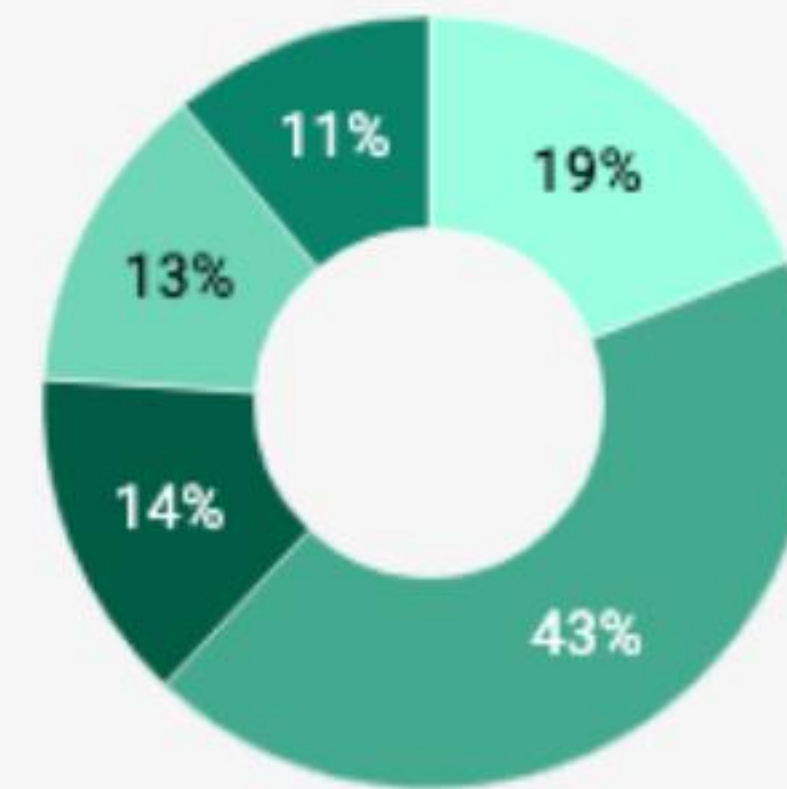
NFL



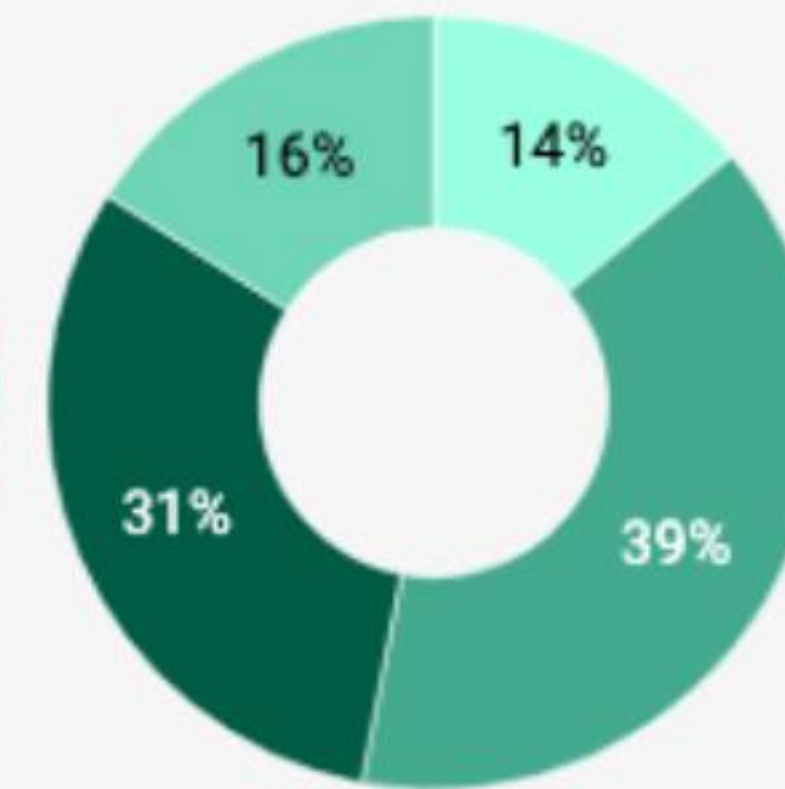
MLB



NBA

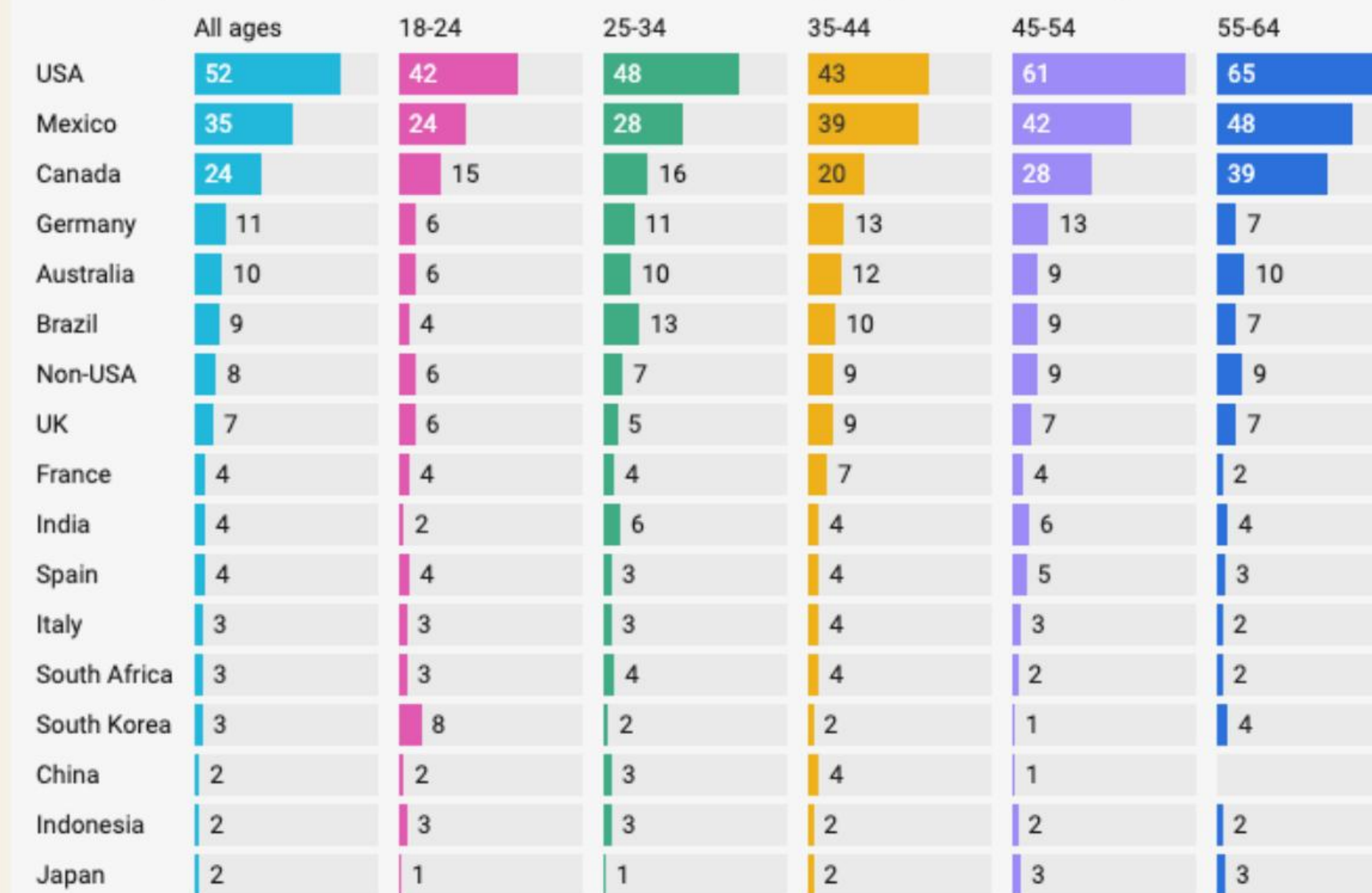


NHL



MLS

% of sports fans who follow the NFL by Age & Country



Why was the preceding information important?

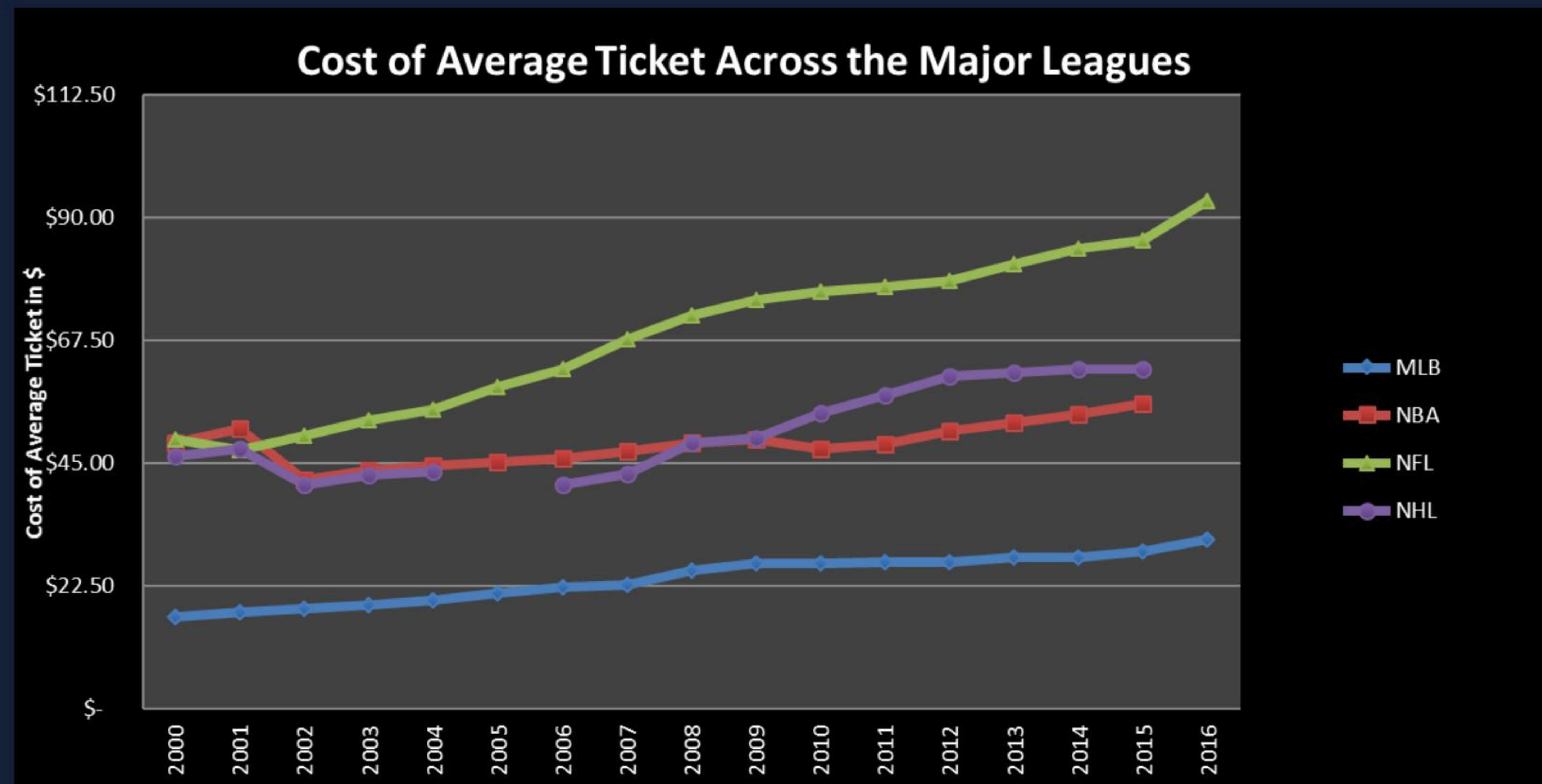
Because all of this indicates that sport managers and marketers need to put renewed emphasis on maintaining and developing relationships with fans and spectators.

Changes

- However, there are some issues that exist.
- SBJ along with the ESPN Sports Poll has shown that the percentage of fans earning less than \$30,000 a year has dropped in all of the Major Sports.
- The percentage of fans earning more than \$100,000 has increased in all sports.
- *Is this a problem? Why or why not?*

Ticket Costs

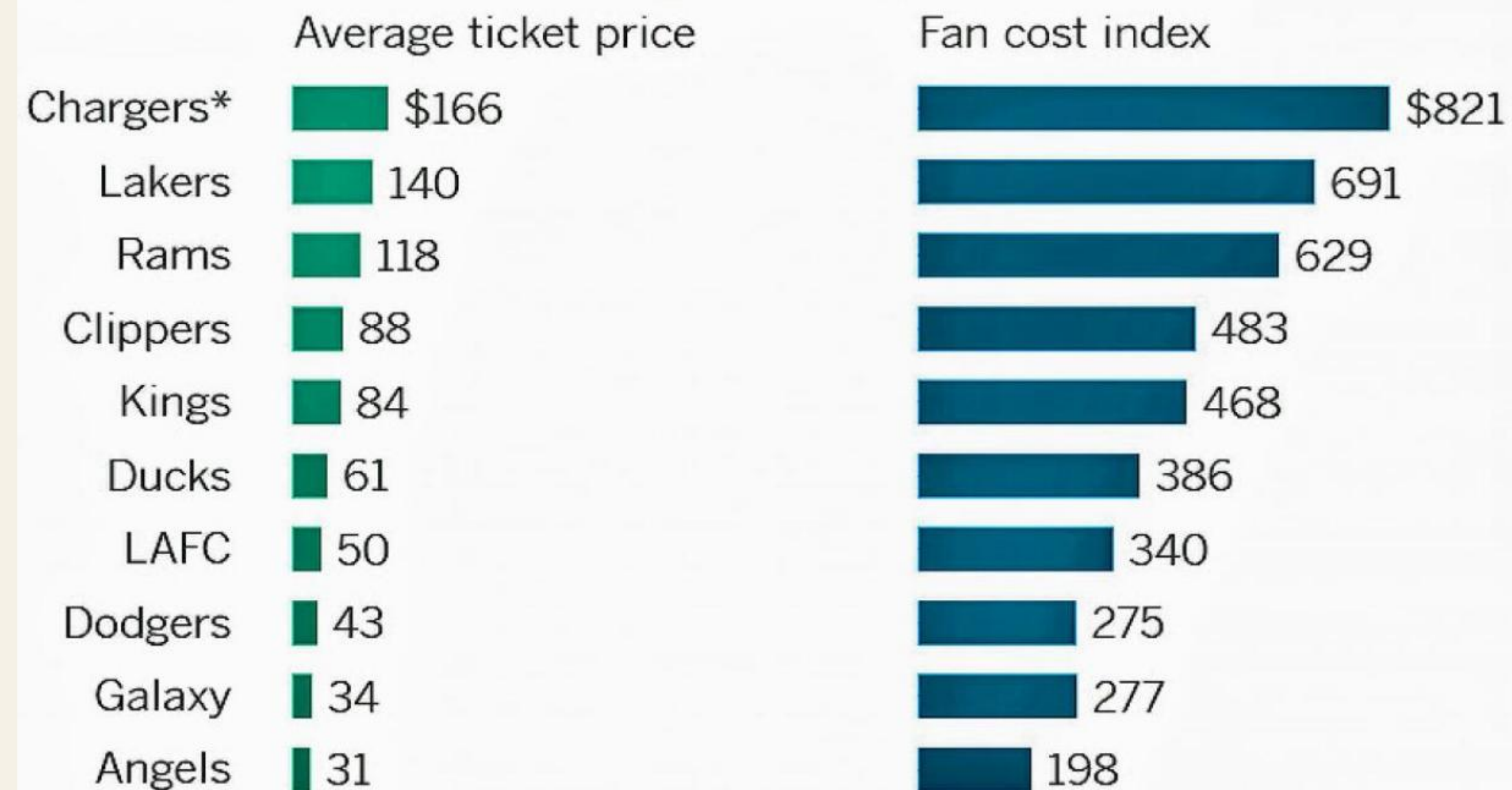
- *Do you see a potential problem here? Why or why not?*



Ticket Costs cont.

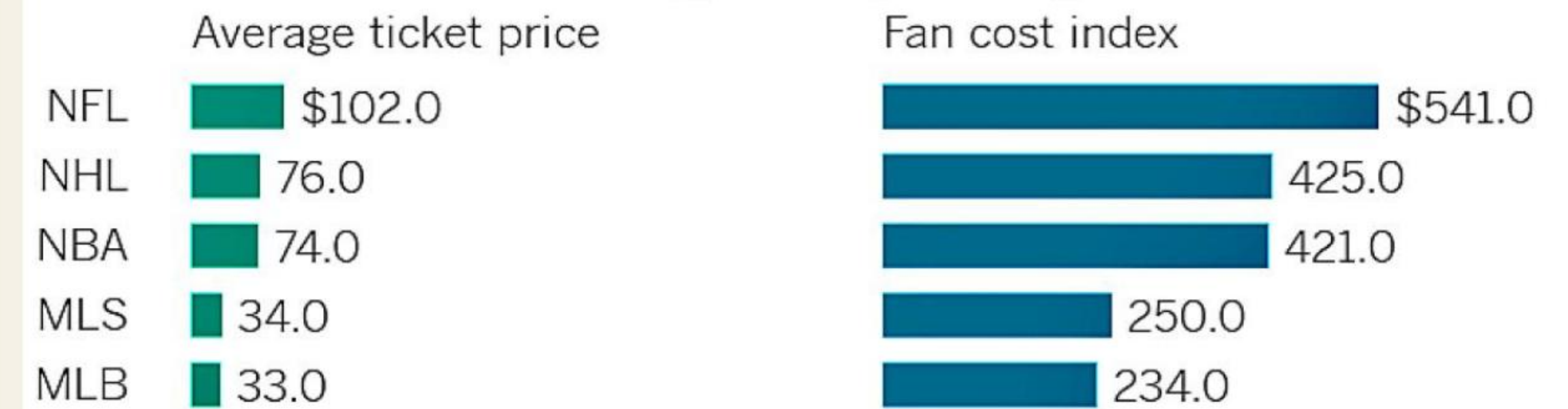
- *Do you see a potential problem here? Why or why not?*

How much it costs to go to a game in L.A.



Source: Team Marketing Report. *Chargers set to drop significantly in 2020. @latimesports

How much it costs to go to sporting events



Source: Team Marketing Report

@latimesports

Fans

This is causing an economic disconnect with this market segment and creating disgruntled fans. It is reasonable to expect that these fans will be less likely to purchase merchandise. Eventually these people may cease to be fans because of their dissatisfaction with the team and their perception of how they were treated. Many of these fans have been loyal for quite some time and perceive that their loyalty is not being rewarded.

- *Why are the following issues a potential problem?*
- Economic disconnect
- Less likely to purchase merchandise
- May cease to be fans
- Loyal fans perceive that they are not being rewarded



Why do we care that Sport Differs from other Products?

- Sport is simultaneously produced and consumed.
- Sport is unpredictable and inconsistent.
- Sport is experiential, subjective, intangible, and ephemeral.
- Sport has a high degree of social facilitation.
- Sport can elicit strong emotions and can be strongly personal.
- The core product is beyond the marketer's control.
- Sport organizations simultaneously must cooperate and compete.
- Sport consumers think of themselves as experts in the field/industry.
- The price of the product can be a small part of the total cost or experience.
- Indirect revenues can be greater than direct revenues.

Sport Consumers

- Consumers have a direct impact on sport organizations through their attending, viewing, and purchasing behaviors.
- Consumers also have an indirect impact in terms of the attractiveness of a consumer base for prospective sponsors and other business partners.
- *Why is it imperative that the people working in sport organizations and sponsors of sport teams and events better understand why spectators consume and how to get them to consume more?*



Why do you need to be able to answer the following questions?

- *How well do you know your customers/clients?*
- *What kind of information do you have about them?*
- *How is this information stored and how accessible is it to people within your organization?*

Why do you need to be able to answer the following questions?

- *Can you segment your customers/clients based on useful criteria that will allow you to be more efficient in your marketing?*
- *If so, what information do you have that will help you create useful market segments?*
- *How do you know that the segments are distinct enough to make it financially feasible to target them separately?*
- *If not, how can you gather information that will allow you to segment them?*



Why do you need to be able to answer the following questions?

- *Do you know what makes fans/spectators happy and satisfied when they are in the venue? If so, what?*
- *Do you know how to develop relationships with them that will maximize per client revenues and maximizes ROI for your organization?*

Thank you!